

PUREPOLITICS

PM Flays GDP Critics, Says They're Unable to Digest India's Strength



Prime Minister Narendra Modi countered the controversy over the 7.8% growth figures, emphasising that it has come amid world turmoil, reports **Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi**. He attacked critics of the government, saying those who had pushed India into the 'fragile five' were questioning efforts made for the country's progress. Modi was speaking at an event amid centenary celebrations of Shri Ram College of Commerce. >>> 2

■ **All 10 Accused Convicted for '13 Chh'garh Naxal Attack** >>> 2

■ **Iran CJ Seeks Prosecution of War Crimes at BRICS Forum** >>> 2

ET WEALTH ON MONDAY



MORE ACTION TAKEN

CBI Books Chandra, Others in ₹1,322cr LICHFL Fraud Case

Essel chairman faces criminal charges, ED's PMLA probe

The Essel Case Files

CBI CHARGES Criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal misconduct

ED PROBE Money laundering

LICHFL COMPLAINT Multiple net worth certificates for Subhash Chandra issued in 2018

MARCH 28: ₹59,113.21 cr as of March 31, 2017

JULY 6: ₹40,562 cr



Loan disbursed on basis of these declarations

But position changed during personal insolvency

Net worth in 2024 was ₹31.79 cr, said Chandra

Didn't top ₹40,000 cr even in 2017-18, he said

Lender says higher net worth shown for getting loan

Personal guarantees given for facilities on March 28 and August 10, 2018

Significant flight risk highlighted

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Central Bureau of Investigation has registered an FIR against Subhash Chandra and eight others in connection with alleged inflation of the Essel Group chairman's net worth to obtain loans from LIC Housing Finance (LICHFL), which caused it a loss of more than ₹1,322 crore, said people with knowledge of the matter.

Separately, the Directorate of Enforcement will launch a money laundering probe and register an Enforcement Case Information Report under relevant provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act against Chandra and the co-accused, according to people in the know.

LICHFL alleged in its complaint that the loans were sanctioned on the basis of the disputed net worth certificates submitted by Chandra and that the subsequent conduct of the borrowers was aimed at frustrating recovery.

It also claimed that Chandra submitted two net worth certificates in March and July 2018 that were used to secure approval and disbursement of two loans totalling ₹980 crore.

Chandra, Pankaj Suroliya, Amish Pandya, Rajeev Dholakia and other entities have been named as accused. The case relates to credit facilities extended in 2018 to companies associated with Essel Group. The allegations include criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal misconduct.

LICHFL's complaint is part of the CBI first information report (FIR) registered last Monday.

Govt Officials Also Under Lens >>> 7

FRONT-OF-PACK FOOD LABELS

Warning Needed for Even Single Excess Ingredient: Plea in SC

Petitioner calls for one-phase rollout of FSSAI measures to avoid loopholes

Shambhavi Anand

New Delhi: Products high in salt, sugar or fat could be able to dodge the food safety regulator's proposed labelling on packaged food and beverages in the first phase, according to a Supreme Court petition, urging these measures be rolled out in entirety to ensure full implementation.

The petitioner, while seeking changes to the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI) latest proposal, said the first phase of implementation of front-of-pack warning labels will require a product to be high in two or more specified nutrients before a warning is triggered. The petition was filed by 3S and Our Health Society, a non-profit. A product extremely high in sugar alone, for instance, therefore, won't feature any health warning if it also doesn't have high salt or saturated fat content, the petitioner argued.

Total Amount, Not Part Added >>> 7

AHEAD OF FESTIVE SEASON...

There's a Lot Riding on Cos Getting Rural 2-wheeler Mix Right

Mkt accounts for 55% registrations in H1

Lijee Philip

Mumbai: Two-wheeler makers face a more complicated rural stocking challenge ahead of the festive season with rural markets accounting for more than half of industry sales.

What sells in one rural market can be very different from another: entry-level motorcycles in some states, higher-capacity bikes or scooters in others, and electric vehicles adding another layer. The difference matters because rural markets accounted for 55% of all two-wheeler registrations in January-June 2026, compared with 32% for urban markets and 13% for metros. For manufacturers and dealers, getting the overall rural demand forecast right may not be enough if the product mix is wrong.

Flexible Supply Chain >>> 7

US SAYS ATTACKS, INCLUDING ONE OFF KHARG ISLAND, IN RETALIATION

US Missiles Hit Three Iranian Oil Tankers

US forces struck three Iranian oil tankers on Saturday, including one off the coast of Kharg Island, near Iran's key oil export hub. The strikes were carried out after Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps launched ballistic missiles at two American Navy ships, Central Command said. Locals said there were no casualties and the crew of the tanker near Kharg was being evacuated. >>> 7

INDIA BACKS UNGA RESOLUTION ENDORSING NEW WORLD MAP >>> 3

Gen Z Makes Luxe Watches Get with Time(s)

Swiss brands mull bolder innovation amid changing tastes, rivals & shrinking revenue

Bloomberg

The luxury watch industry needs bigger, bolder innovation and ideas to lure new customers as it hits the limits of its well-worn strategy of boosting revenue with ever-pricier offerings.

That's the view of some industry executives at the annual watch world post-summer gathering this week in Geneva. A record 71 brands set up shop in hotel rooms, boutiques and exhibition spaces to display their wares, but the bullish attendance figures belied watchmakers' worries over the future.

After years of perfecting a blueprint for making more money through the sales of fewer but more expensive timepieces, Swiss watchmakers face younger consumers with less money to spend and a different view on what makes a luxury watch desirable. That, together with a booming resale market and competition from Japanese and credible Chinese contenders, is shrinking Swiss watchmakers' exports, making the trends a more worrisome development than the war in the Middle East.

"Today, that's the main challenge of the industry," Jean-Christophe Babin, president of Geneva Watch Days and chairman of Bulgari, said in an interview. Switzerland, which is the undisputed global leader of the luxury watch industry, exported only 14.6 million timepieces last year compared with 25.4 million in 2016, according to the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry.

Moving Further Upmarket >>> 7

Switzerland exported **14.6m** timepieces last year compared with **25.4m** in 2016

Mid-market players and suppliers hit hard

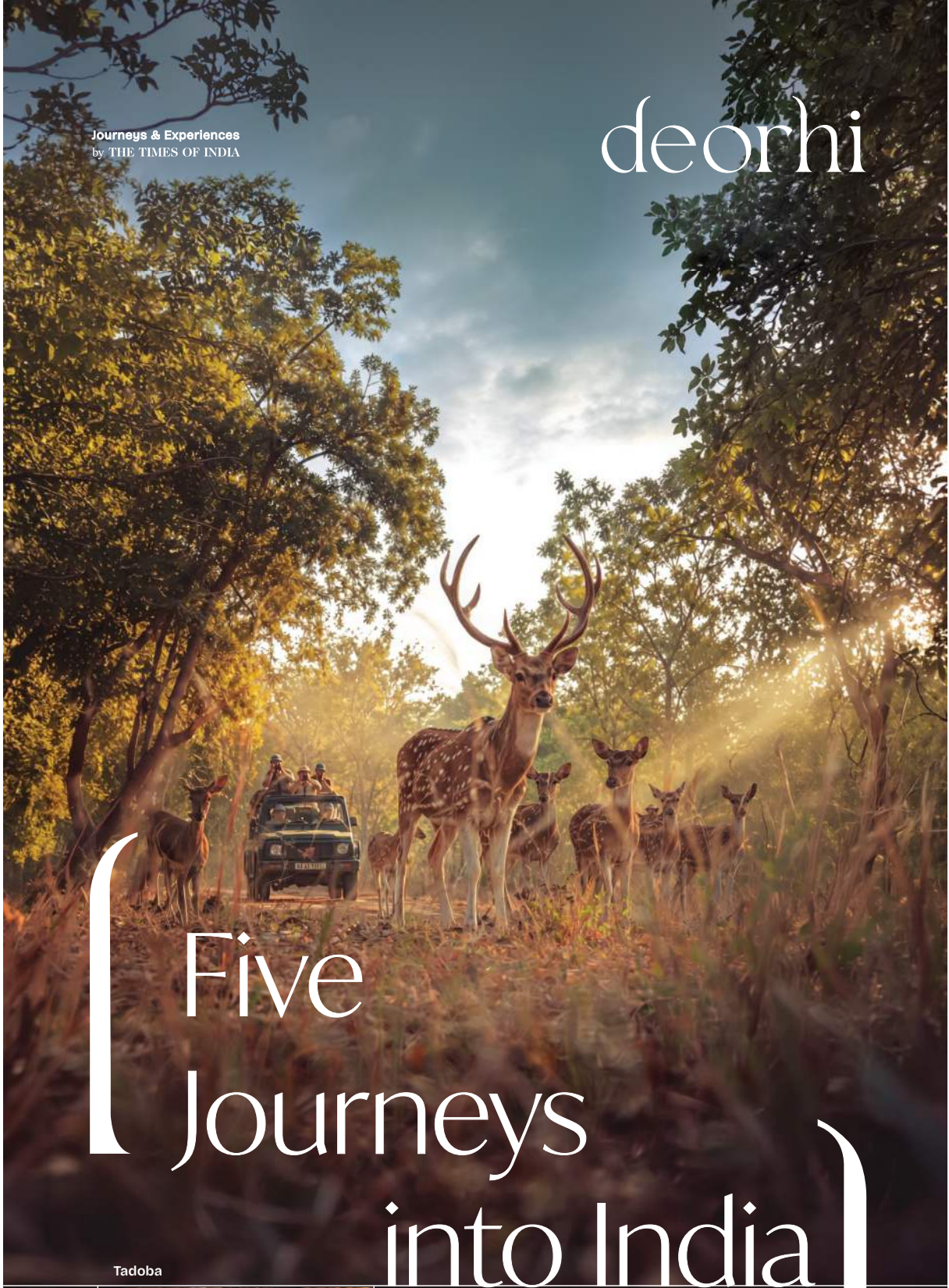


Gen Z & young millennials less driven by status & brand loyalty

Competition intensifying from Japan, China

Journeys & Experiences by THE TIMES OF INDIA

deorhi

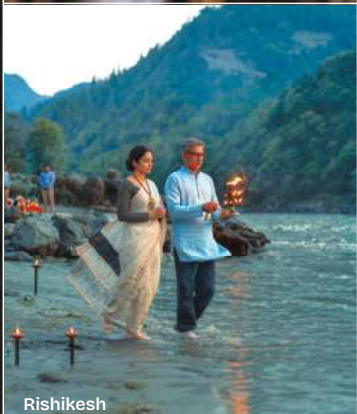


Five Journeys into India

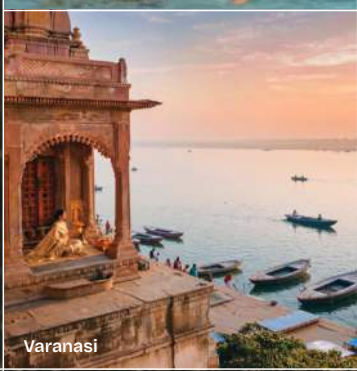
Tadoba



Sikkim



Rishikesh



Varanasi



Ladakh

30 Sept - 5 Oct '26 **Ladakh, Lived**
Leh • Nubra • Turtuk

27 Oct - 1 Nov '26 **Hymns of the Ganga**
Haridwar • Rishikesh

22 - 25 Oct '26 **The Language of Tadoba**
Tadoba Tiger Reserve

28 Oct - 4 Nov '26 **Sikkim, Unhurried**
Yumthang • Darjeeling • Lachung

8 - 13 Dec '26 **Sacred Currents**
Ayodhya • Sarnath • Varanasi

deorhi.com

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PUNISHMENT TO BE ANNOUNCED ON 16TH

10 Convicted in Jheeram Ghati Naxal Attack

11 senior Congress leaders, many security personnel were killed in 2013 ambush

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: A special NIA court has convicted all 10 accused for planning and executing the 2013 Naxal attack in Chhattisgarh, which had wiped out almost the state's entire Congress leadership. Special Judge of the National Investigation Agency court in Jagdalpur, Abhay Singh Rajput, convicted the 10 accused, including 2 women, defence lawyer Arvind Choudhary said in Jagdalpur.

The order on the quantum of punishment has been reserved for September 16, he said, adding that statements of 101 witnesses were recorded during the trial, he said. We will appeal against the verdict in the higher court. We have not received the copy of the judgment. We will be able to give the grounds for appeal after receiving it," Choudhary added.



FILE PHOTO

le to give the grounds for appeal after receiving it," Choudhary added.

The convicted individuals are Pramila Modiyam, Chaitu Lekam alias Munna, Sumitra alias Sumitra Punem Modiyam, Mukka Mandvi, Kosa Kavasi alias Kosaram, Aayata Markam, Madkami

Deva, Joga Madkami, Banjami Anna alias Chamru alias Denga, and Mahadev Nag.

The incident had taken place in Bastar's Jheeram Ghati on 25 May 2013, when the Congress leaders were holding a 'Parivartan rally' ahead of the 2013 state elections. According

to reports from the time, around 250 naxals in civilian clothes had launched the attack. Eleven senior Congress party leaders were killed, including then state party chief Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinesh Patel, former Leader of Opposition Mahendra Karma, former Union minister V.C. Shukla, former MLA Uday Mudliyar and local Congress leader Yogendra Sharma. Several security personnel were also killed.

The main target was Mahendra Karma, who was leading Salwa Judum, a state-backed movement against Maoist insurgency which involved arming of local youths. It was later declared illegal and unconstitutional by the Supreme Court.

The NIA took over the probe into the case and charged a total of 39 cadres of the banned outfit, including one Barse Sukka, alias Deva. Deva was then in-charge of the Darbha Divisional Committee and was appointed the overall commander to carry out the attack by the top leadership of the banned outfit, according to investigators. Deva had surrendered before Telangana Police in January this year. (With Agency's Inputs)



PM Modi being greeted during the centenary celebrations of SRCC – PTI

ADDRESSING STUDENTS AT SRCC

PM Slams Critics, Oppn 'Pessimism' on 7.8% Growth

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi countered the controversy over the 7.8% growth figures, emphasising that this has come about at a time when the world is reeling under the impact of the West Asia crisis and the challenges to international trade. He attacked the Opposition and critics of the government, saying those who had pushed India to one of the "fragile five" economies are today adopting a pessimistic attitude and questioning all efforts being made for the country's progress.

Addressing students of Shree Ram College of Commerce on its centenary celebrations here, the prime minister recalled his earlier visit to the institution in 2013 as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate and said the situation prevailing in the country then was gloomy and compared it to the present. The headlines in newspaper and news channels then talked of corruption, cross border terrorism, soldiers getting killed at LOC, high inflation and Current Account Deficit, India in fragile five, and policy paralysis while today there is tremendous growth in manu-

facturing sectors, indigenous defence production, peace in Jammu and Kashmir and the North-East, terrorism down, and Atmanirbharta (self-reliance).

"When I came here in 2013, I had talked about three types of people: those who say the glass is half full, those who say it is half-empty and those who say it is full-half with water and the other half with air. In 2013, the country was steeped in depression. I had said that the glass is full," Modi said, adding that India has now moved to policy dynamism and is the fastest growing major economy in the world.



Modi says those who once pushed India into 'fragile five' now question its progress

The prime minister's interaction with the Gen Z crowd has come dares after the Jantar Mantar protests by students over the NEET paper leak issue.

Modi underscored that the 7.8% growth figure has increased the enthusiasm all around. "The Japanese rating agency has also upgraded India's rating..." he said.

AT BRICS FORUM, CJI CALLS FOR COMMON ARBITRATION PLATFORM

Iran CJ Seeks Action Over War Crimes, Sovereignty Violations

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Iran's Chief Justice Ayatollah Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Ejei Saturday called for stronger international action against those responsible for what Tehran described as violations of its sovereignty, war crimes, and crimes against humanity.

Also speaking at the BRICS Chief Justices' Forum, Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant proposed a common BRICS platform for arbitration and mediation to resolve cross-border commercial disputes.

The head of Iran's judiciary called on BRICS member states to uphold the rule of law and take a firm stand against aggression, violations of national sovereignty and



CJI Kant with Chief Justice of Iran Gholamhossein Mohseni-Ejei in New Delhi – PTI

international crimes, making a pointed reference to military strikes by Israel and the US against his country earlier this year.

Mohseni-Ejei said justice should not be selective or shaped by political considerations or the relative power of countries. He stressed respect for international law, national sovereignty and territorial

integrity, and said no country should regard itself as being above the law.

"BRICS has an increasingly important role in shaping the emerging global order," he said. "We seek an order in which no power considers itself above the law," he said, calling upon BRICS members to "stand with the law".

BUDGAM ENCOUNTER

Pakistani Killed Identified as LeT Man

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The infiltrator killed in an operation in the upper reaches of Budgam district in central Kashmir has been identified as Pakistani national Yasir, who had been associated with Lashkar-e-Taiba and allegedly involved in the ambush of an Indian Air Force convoy in Poonch and an attack on army and civilian workers in 2024, officials said on Saturday.

They said the joint search operation continued in Ashdar Gali, also known as Ashtar Gali, in the upper reaches of Budgam for the second infiltrator, Musa, who was reportedly hiding in natural caves around the encounter site—located between 12,000 and 15,500 feet in the Pir Panjal range.

Officials said Yasir had been on the radar of the security forces since 2024 and was involved in at least three major incidents that year, including an ambush of an air force convoy in Poonch district, an attack on construction workers near Sonamarg and an attack on the army in Bota Pathri in Gulmarg area.

An air force member was killed and four others injured when infiltrators ambushed a convoy of the force in J&K's Poonch district. The attack took place near Shahsitar in the Surankote area on May 4, 2024, when the troops were returning to their base at Sanaai Top.



Yasir was involved in Poonch IAF convoy ambush, 2024 attacks on workers and Army



Former YSRCP MP Vijay Sai Reddy to Launch Party

Former YSR Congress Rajya Sabha MP Vijay Sai Reddy is set to launch a new party in Andhra Pradesh. Reddy, a close associate of former CM Jagan Mohan Reddy, quit the party in January 2025. At the time, he had said he would retire from politics to pursue his own interests.

Reddy announced in a post on X that he would address a press conference in Vijayawada on September 7. "Apart from raising the issues faced by people of Andhra, I will highlight how the prevailing two-party model is failing to reflect the will, aspirations and interests of

the common man," Reddy told ET. "It has become a two-family rule in Andhra and there is a need for an alternative party that works for the people and puts their interests at the centre of governance," he said.

Reddy said he would launch a new party and work to offer people an alternative to break the hegemony of two families. To begin with, he will address four press conferences, starting with Vijayawada on September 7. He will hold three more conferences in Tirupati, Anantapur and Vishakhapatnam.



CM Calls Alliance Meet Amid 'Vijay for PM' Push

Tamil Nadu CM Vijay has called an alliance meeting in Chennai on September 9 to resolve issues and improve coordination. The government has completed 100 days, but the alliance has been in the news for all the wrong reasons.

Some senior TVK ministers are openly pitching 'Vijay for PM' in 2029, with Aadhav Arjuna and MLA Kanimozhi Santhosh backing him. Santhosh has also said Rahul Gandhi would make way for Vijay as the opposition PM candidate from the south.

The remarks did not go down well with Congress,

which is part of the government in the state. Tamil Nadu Congress president Manickam Tagore reiterated that Rahul Gandhi will be the PM candidate from the opposition and no one else.

TVK ministers Aadhav Arjuna and N Anand met Tagore after the initial statements and invited him to the alliance meeting on September 9. Tagore has said he will attend the meeting. However, the Left parties, CPI and CPM, have not yet decided whether to attend. The parties did not attend the last alliance meeting in July.

AICC RESHUFFLE

Congress Begins Punjab Clean-Up; Pilot In, Baghel Out as In-Charge

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Congress high command on Saturday night signalled its eagerness to clean up the mess created by infighting in poll-bound Punjab Congress. In a select shuffle of party pointsmen for states, the leadership shunted out Bhupesh Baghel, who as AICC general secretary in-charge of the state had failed to contain infighting and had sided with PCC chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, to Assam and brought in Sachin Pilot, who was looking after Chhattisgarh, as the

new AICC general secretary in-charge of the poll-bound border state. This shuffle strengthens the possibility of more changes in the Punjab Congress organisational structure.

The new shuffle also showed K C Venugopal continuing in the key post of AICC general secretary in-charge of organisation, while Priyanka Gandhi Vadra remains AICC

general secretary without specific charge. However, Randeep Singh Surjewala, who is in charge of party-ruled Karnataka, gets additional charge of Gujarat, which will have elections next year.

While Jitendra Singh, who was AICC in-charge of Assam when the party lost elections, is relieved of the AICC post, outgoing in-charge of Gujarat Mukul Wasnik is retained as AICC general secretary without charge. Ramesh Chennithala, who is now the Home Minister of Kerala, is relieved of his AICC in-charge of Maharashtra, where debutant Sirivella Prasad is given charge.

MARATHA QUOTA AGITATION

Jarange Patil Stops Water, Saline on 8th Day of Fast

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: Putting further pressure on the Maharashtra government to act on his demands, Maratha leader Manoj Jarange Patil has stopped taking water and his intravenous drip (saline) as he enters the eighth day of his fast.

Jarange Patil is fasting at Antarvali Sarati village in Jalna, seeking Kumbi caste certificates for the Marathwada's Maratha community, which would make them eligible for OBC reservations.

Late on Friday night, Jarange Patil decided to stop taking saline and water, angry that the two-day deadline he had given the government to issue a Government Resolution (order) on Maratha quotas was not adhered to.

Upping the ante, the Maratha leader also refused to let doctors at the



Jarange Patil

protest site examine him. Turning the doctors away, Jarange Patil said, "I will not take anything and will not undergo any treatment, until the government begins implementing all our demands and starts taking action on the ground."

Jarange Patil, who was on a fast,

began taking water and had taken saline after BJP MLC Prasad Lad, considered to be close to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, visited him last week and promised him to start taking water and saline while assuring him that his demands would soon be implemented.

Patil claims that the government delegation, including Prasad Lad, had assured him last week that after verification, 58 lakh Kumbi caste certificates as per the Hyderabad Gazette would immediately be given. "They had promised me that they would begin issuing 58 lakh caste certificates and would, at the village level, invite Maratha applicants to apply for the caste certificate, but there has been no progress on it," he said.

Jarange Patil has warned that after September 12, thousands of Maratha protesters would enter Mumbai to begin their protest.

YSRCP Flags Financial Irregularities, MSME Closures in Andhra Pradesh

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) leader PV Nara Chandrababu Naidu led Andhra Pradesh government's economic performance, highlighting closures of micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and asserting that investment inflows had fallen well short of the TDP-led government's projections.

Reddy said that, as per the Union

MSME ministry, 4,520 MSMEs shut down in Andhra Pradesh between 2024-25 and June 30 this year, affecting units that employed 48,477 people. The data showed that 1,401 MSMEs closed in 2024-25, 2,407 in 2025-26 and another 712 during the first quarter of this financial year.

He further said that a reply by the commerce and industry ministry showed that only 10 investment proposals have been grounded in Andhra Pradesh over

the past two years, which, according to him, fell far short of the projections and investment claims repeatedly made by the TDP government and Naidu.

JAGAN ACCUSES STATE GOVT OF SOCIAL MEDIA CURBS

YSRCP chief Jagan Mohan Reddy accused the TDP-led Andhra government of suppressing voices questioning the alleged DSC-2025 teachers recruitment scam by restricting or removing social media content critical of the government.

PDA Dig, 4Cs Focus: Tawde Begins Mission UP

'SP's PDA means Paraya Dhan Apna. NDA will never let this happen,' says BJP UP Incharge

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: Keeping the optics low-key but the politics and organisational high-voltage, BJP's new Uttar Pradesh in-charge Vinod Tawde wasted no time in signalling his intent, opening his first visit to the state with a sharp dig at Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav's PDA plank before getting down to the BJP's 2027 groundwork.

Making it equally clear that his assignment would be driven by teamwork rather than individual projection, Tawde repeatedly in-

voiced the BJP's collective leadership -- from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, party chief Nitin Nabin, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, to Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and the state organisation -- signalling his emphasis on taking everyone along as the party gears up for the 2027 Assembly elections.

Sources in the BJP said his immediate organisational focus is expected to revolve around the 4Cs -- coordination, cadres, caste and candidature -- with a special emphasis on nearly 100 Assembly constituencies where the BJP underperformed in the 2024 Lok Sabha elec-



Vinod Tawde in Lucknow – ANI

tions. Setting the political tone for his new assignment, Tawde took direct aim at Akhilesh Yadav's much-publicised PDA (Pichhda, Dalit,

Alpsankhyak) formula, giving the acronym a fresh political twist.

"PDA and SP mean 'Paraya Dhan Apna'. NDA will never let this happen," he told reporters after arriving in Lucknow, signalling that the BJP intends to take on the Samajwadi Party's social coalition narrative head-on.

His understated arrival also reflected his working style. Tawde asked party workers to avoid elaborate hoardings and grand receptions, preferring to devote the visit to organisational meetings and election planning rather than public spectacle.

RABIES VACCINE

ILL: Seized Abhayrab Vials Not Made by Co

Teena Thacker

New Delhi: Indian Immunologicals Limited (ILL) on Saturday said the vials of its rabies vaccine Abhayrab found substandard and potentially spurious were not manufactured by the company. The statement comes after India's drug regulator deemed the batch substandard, following a government laboratory finding that the field sample failed a potency test and was classified as "not of standard quality".



However, ILL, one of India's leading vaccine manufacturers, said in a statement that the particular batch was tested and released by the government's Central Drugs Laboratory (CDL), Kasauli, and that the released quantity of 83,370 vials was supplied only through the company's authorised distribution channel.

"No market complaint has been received in respect of the batch Number KE25012," the statement said. The company said every batch of Abhayrab is released for sale only after independent testing and batch release certification by the CDL.

"Vaccine administered at a hospital, clinic, government facility or licensed pharmacy reaches the patient through that released and authorised supply chain and is not affected by this matter," it said. The company said 17 differences were recorded between the seized vials and the retention samples of the same batch held at the CDL. During an enforcement action, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation drew vaccine samples from an unlicensed residential premises in Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi.

Global Hotel Chains Step up India Presence as Luxury Demand Rises

Banyan Tree evaluates India entry; Kerten Hospitality enters market with 1,000-key plan

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: India's expanding hospitality sector is set to get more vibrant as new international hotel chains plan their entry, while existing ones introduce new luxury and lifestyle branded properties.

Singapore-based luxury chain Banyan Tree is seriously evaluating opportunities in India, people familiar with the matter told ET. Ireland-based Kerten Hospitality announced its India entry this March, with an initial plan for around 1,000 keys. Banyan Tree didn't respond to an email query.

Thailand-based Dusit made an India comeback last year, while Hyatt is actively scouting for locations for its boutique hotel brand

Standard acquired as part of its \$335 million purchase of Standard International in 2024. Marriott International is planning to introduce its big box hotel brand Marriott Marquis and mid-scale brand City Express in India, while Hilton is working on the launches of Waldorf Astoria hotels.

Marriott announced the global launch of the Serres by Marriott portfolio in India through a deal with Concept Hospitality last year. IHG Hotels & Resorts said it is launching its Kimpton brand in India through a deal with Adani Airport Hol-

Grand Arrivals

Dusit made a comeback in India last year

Hyatt is scouting locations for its boutique hotel brand Standard

Marriott plans to introduce Marriott Marquis and City Express in India

Hilton is working on the launch of Waldorf Astoria hotels

IHG Hotels & Resorts is launching its Kimpton brand in India

ITC Hotels unveiled Epiq Collection to accelerate growth in the premium segment

dings in May. Last October, ITC Hotels unveiled its new brand called Epiq Collection to accelerate growth in the premium segment. Chalet Hotels also announced the launch of ATHIVA Hotels & Resorts last year, while Sayaji Hotels has incubated the Altara luxury hotel vertical focused on wed-

ding and MICE demand. Nandivardhan Jain, founder and CEO at NOESIS Hotel Advisors said 2025 and 2026 are the "widest wave" of first-time brand entries in India witnessed since the 2007-2010 period. He said the rise and launch of new brands in India has been 'steep'.

TOGO-SPONSORED RESOLUTION GETS 164 VOTES

India Votes for UN Resolution on More Accurate World Map



PTI

United Nations: India has voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a "more accurate representation" of continental landmasses.

The 193-member UN General Assembly on Friday overwhelmingly adopted the resolution "Correct the map": rebalancing global cartographic representation and promoting equitable representation of the world's regions, particularly Africa'.

Resolution also noted with "concern" that "this distortion contributes to minimising the perceived sizes of Africa, Latin America and South Asia"

United States.

The resolution noted that the Mercator projection, designed in the 16th century for navigational purposes, remains widely used in educational, media, digital and official materials, despite the considerable distortion of landmasses to the North and South, far from the equator. The resolution also noted with "concern" that "this distortion contributes to minimising the perceived sizes of Africa, Latin America and South Asia, and perpetuating an unbalanced view of the world." In an explanation of the vote in the General Assembly,

First Secretary at the Permanent Mission of India to the UN, Raghoo Puri, said India "welcomes" the intention behind the resolution to promote more accurate and representative cartographic practices.

"We believe that maps play an important role in how societies understand geography and the relative scale of the world around us," he said. However, India clarified its understanding of the scope of this resolution, saying, "We believe that the resolution should be understood as supporting the broader use and consideration of Equal Area map projections, and not as endorsing the Equal Earth projection or any other specific map projection."

Equal Area projections are particularly relevant because they preserve the relative sizes or areas of continental and territorial landmasses, Puri said.

"This can help address distortions in perceived landmass size that arise from projections designed primarily to preserve other geographic characteristics such as shape, direction, or distance. At the same time, different projections serve different cartographic purposes. No single projection is necessarily appropriate for every application. "Therefore, we believe it is important for this resolution to remain technological and methodological-neutral. Our delegation supports the language that encourages accurate cartographic representation while allowing countries, institutions and cartographers to determine which projection is most appropriate for their specific needs," Puri said.

PROJECT EXPECTED TO CREATE THOUSANDS OF DIRECT, INDIRECT JOBS

TCS HyperVault To Build ₹70,000-Cr AI Data Centre Campus in Hyderabad

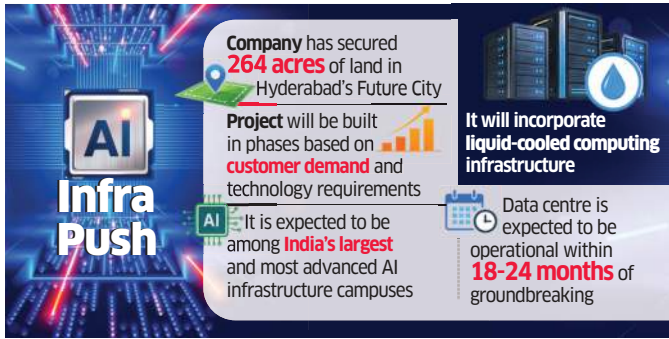
To cater to frontier AI cos, hyperscalers to support high-density GPU deployments for AI training

Our Bureau

Hyderabad: HyperVault, a unit of Tata Consultancy Services, is investing up to ₹70,000 crore to build a 1 GW AI data centre campus in Hyderabad, marking one of India's largest planned investments in AI infrastructure.

The company has secured 264 acres of land at Hyderabad's Future City to develop the largest scale AI data centre campus, catering to frontier AI companies and hyperscalers to support high-density GPU deployments for AI training, inference and advanced computing workloads. The project will be built in phases based on customer demand and technology needs.

At full build-out, the campus is expected to be among India's largest and most advanced AI in-



frastructure campuses. HyperVault said in a statement. It will incorporate liquid-cooled compute infrastructure, green energy and water-neutral design principles.

The project is expected to create thousands of direct and indirect jobs and drive demand across po-

wer, cooling, networking, construction, engineering and data-centre operations.

TCS CEO and MD K Krithivasan said the AI data centre campus will advance the company's "Infrastructure-to-Intelligence" strategy by combining AI-ready infrastructure with its cloud,

engineering, enterprise transformation and AI capabilities.

"AI is a civilisational shift and will change everything we do today," Krithivasan said, adding Hyderabad offers the scale, talent and ecosystem required to serve global customers.

Speaking to reporters, Krithivasan said the data centre will be operational in 18-24 months from groundbreaking. In response, chief minister Revanth Reddy asked TCS to inaugurate the data centre by June 2, 2028, assuring all required sanctions to speed up the process. The data centre plan followed a conversation between Reddy and Tata Sons chairman N Chandrasekaran at Davos in January this year, said D Sridhar Babu, Telangana IT and industries minister. He said the project would create up to 7,000 direct and indirect jobs.

Talcher Fertilisers, NTPC Apply for Coal Gasification Scheme

Our Bureau

The coal ministry on Saturday said Talcher Fertilisers Ltd and NTPC Ltd have informed that they have submitted applications under the government's coal and lignite gasification scheme. The first application window under the scheme is open until September 7.

The ministry said it was also in discussions with other prospective applicants at different stages of project preparation and are in the process of finalising their proposals.

The scheme for promotion of surface coal and lignite gasification projects was approved by the Cabinet on May 13 with a total financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore.

It is aimed to promote the conversion of domestic coal and lignite into higher-value products, including syngas, methanol, ammonia and urea. The request for proposals

under the scheme was issued on July 7. The government expects more applications as the deadline approaches. Applications will be invited through rolling rounds. Once one application window closes, the next round will open from the following day and remain open for two months, allowing companies additional time to prepare projects.

The scheme is part of the government's broader effort to expand coal gasification in India and cut the dependence on imports of products that can potentially be produced from domestic coal and lignite. Gasification converts coal into syngas, which can then be used to produce chemicals, fertilisers, fuels and other industrial products.



The first application window under the scheme is open until September 7

Coal India Offers Road Route to Power Plants to Augment Coal Supplies

Our Bureau

State-run miner Coal India has offered thermal plants having fuel supply agreements the option to lift additional coal, including beyond their annual contracted amounts, through road transport, as part of efforts to expeditiously boost supplies to the power sector.

Some plants are facing coal stock depletion amid elevated electricity demand in several parts of the country facing an uncertain and challenging summer and forecasts of strong El Nino weather conditions. Coal supplies, though higher year-on-year, are going through a seasonal slack.

The coal ministry Saturday said Coal India subsidiaries have adequate stocks of the fossil fuel and that the company is seeking to open an additional supply mode alongside the existing rail route.

Coal India currently has 76 million tonnes of coal at its

pitheads, along with 46 million tonnes of ready-to-mine coal exposure, according to the ministry. It highlighted that both production and supply at Coal India are gathering pace and likely to improve further as intense monsoon rains over the coal-bearing regions are starting to show clear signs of easing.

Amid prolonged spells of rain through July and August, particularly across the east-central parts of the country, Coal India maintained a steady supply run, the ministry said. During April-August, the miner supplied 322.9 million tonnes of coal, 6.7% more than a year earlier.

Easing rainfall is already bringing relief on the ground, the ministry said.



Some plants are facing coal stock depletion amid elevated electricity demand in several parts of the country

Anthropic Delays its IPO Plans, Listing Expected in November

Co had been expected to make its IPO prospectus public as early as next week

Reuters

Anthropic is expected to begin marketing its initial public offering in mid-October at the earliest and complete the listing days before the U.S. midterm elections in November, people familiar with the matter said on Friday.

The artificial intelligence company had been expected to make its IPO prospectus public as early as next week, two of the people said, a crucial step that would kick off the final stages of the offering. Now that is not expected until late September, the people added, cautioning that the plans, including the timing, are subject to change.

The shift pushes back what some investors have said could be a \$2 trillion listing, one of the largest IPOs ever attempted and a major test of public-market appetite for the rapidly growing artificial intelligence industry.

Companies frequently adjust their IPO schedules as they work through market



conditions, regulatory reviews and other preparations, so such changes are not unusual.

As part of the IPO process, Anthropic is looking to finalize a \$15 billion revolving credit facility, after which analysts, including those at banks involved in the financing, are expected to meet with the company, one of the people said. Bloom-

berg News earlier reported that Anthropic was in talks to expand the facility to \$15 billion.

Companies typically leave a few weeks between analyst meetings and making the IPO prospectus public, although Anthropic is expected to have a tighter window because analysts already know the company well, the person said.

Anthropic declined to comment. The offering is expected to be one of the most closely anticipated IPOs ever, as investors look to public markets for exposure to the rapidly growing artificial intelligence industry.

It could come alongside potential listings from other AI companies, including OpenAI. Elon Musk's SpaceX went public in June at a record \$1.77 trillion valuation.

Morgan Stanley, Goldman Sachs, JPMorgan and Citi are among the banks working with Anthropic on the IPO, according to people familiar with the matter.

The banks declined to comment.

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What Should the Kids Study in the Age of AI?

Across India, parents are worried about their children's career prospects as AI and immigration policies upset old assumptions about suitable courses and secure jobs

Apoorva Mittal

Aditi Garg has spent hours scanning the undergraduate curricula of universities for her son—the London School of Economics, the National University of Singapore, Ashoka University. Her son is just 15, studying in Class X. She is trying to figure out what he could study a couple of years from now and how relevant that education might be by the time he graduates.

"I am worried," says Mumbai-based Garg, Founder of consumer research firm Out of Syllabus, she is seeing disruption in entry-level jobs in her own line of work—tasks once done by junior employees are now performed by AI. "What is a three- or four-year education going to offer kids? I keep thinking about it," she says. Garg, an alumna of Shri Ram College of Commerce in Delhi and member of the Board of Studies at HSNL University, Mumbai, says legacy institutions aren't keeping pace with the workplace. She says the curriculum for economics and finance is still what she had studied as an undergraduate.

The US's immigration policies have further complicated the situation. Garg and her husband had been clear that their son would study abroad and were close to finalising an education consultant. Now they are not so sure, particularly about US as a higher education destination. "The return on investment on international degrees has decreased. I get resumes from graduates of

Chandra Jandhyala, Class XI, Sophia College for Women: AI has been around for sometime. We have accepted the fact that this is our reality and we have to work with it. I have chosen subjects like history, sociology, economics and psychology based on my interests. Hopefully, my future studies will mirror that.

top universities. They are all coming back to India." Her husband, who works in private equity, jokes that their son might be better off as a chef. "God knows what jobs will exist," she says.

Garg's household is not an exception. Across India, parents are watching their children approach the first consequential decision of their lives—what course to study, what career to pursue—at a time when AI anxiety and geopolitical uncertainty are unsettling decades-long assumptions about secure jobs.

ROUGH WORK

"For two-three decades, parents had a lot of clarity on this front—engineering worked, medicine worked. Now that is being questioned," says Syed Sultan Ahmed, chairperson, The Association of International Schools of India. It has become difficult to study abroad, he notes, while good non-science degree options in India are limited to a handful of universities. A student from a middle- or lower-income background doesn't have many options beyond engineering or medicine, he adds.

Reshma Bachwani, founder of Bengaluru-based consumer insights company Illumine Research, says, "Choosing computer science was a no-brainer once, but that is changing

due to AI. In the last couple of years there is uncertainty about where the careers are going." A parent she knows, an IT worker who quit her job, is adamant that she would not let her daughter study computer engineering. Another parent is opposed to his son pursuing a "niche degree" in data science as he is unsure the job would even exist 10 years from now.

These considerations—breadth over specialisation and possible AI-immune careers—are shaping choices well before

What is a three- or four-year education going to offer kids? God knows what jobs will exist" ADITI GARG, founder, Out of Syllabus, Mumbai

Nupur Amarnath

For years, artists have gazed at the stars for inspiration. In 1888, a year before he painted *The Starry Night*, Vincent van Gogh wrote to his brother Theo: "For my part I know nothing with any certainty, but the sight of the stars makes me dream." A similar spark was ignited in artist Megha Jeevan as she watched the Geminid meteor shower from a beach in Goa in December 2025. She counted 33 falling stars and, "in a very cliché Bollywood way", made a wish on each one. Back home, she challenged herself to remember those wishes and journal about the night. "Once I had all of it on paper, I had this overwhelming urge to share it," recalls Jeevan, 30. "I wanted other people to read these very personal, ordinary little thoughts." The idea for The Scratching Post Mail Club—her art mail club run from her home studio in Mandrem, Goa—was born. Familiar with similar snail-mail clubs abroad, she launched it in January 2026. Today, around 40 subscribers receive a monthly envelope containing a letter, art print, postcard, stickers and a surprise like a playlist or a recipe via Speed Post.

Jeevan's timing is opportune. 2026 is the year of friction-maxxing—deliberately choosing slower, less convenient ways of doing everyday things—and analogue bags stuffed with books, journals, watercolours and other screen-free distractions. Art mail further scratches the analogue itch, tapping into the old-fashioned pleasure of receiving a letter, repackaged as a subscription.

"Art mail is quietly rewriting who gets to collect art. No gallery walls, no gatekeeping, no pretending you know enough about art to buy it. Just an envelope in your hands. It turns collecting into something intimate again"

DIYA SONI, Moo Mail Club, Jaipur



You've Got (Art) Mail

A handful of independent artists are enticing people back into the old world of post with monthly art mail subscriptions

POST MODERN

Typically priced between ₹299 and ₹599 for one mail, the new art subscriptions are newsletters, collectible art drops and pen pal-like correspondence all rolled into one. Periodicity depends on the artist's work cycle—some are monthly, others fortnightly. Subscribers receive specially designed envelopes, often built around a theme, containing anything from prints, stickers, postcards, zines and letters to bookmarks, music and movie recommendations, journaling prompts and activities.

The art mailers are growing. Diya Soni from Jaipur has the Moo Mail Club, Bengaluru-based Udit Goudet's subscription is called Water Lilies, Chennai-based Varsha Prakasham has The Whimsy Paint Mail Club, while Nagaland-based self-taught artist Tim Yanger runs The Orange Boy Nostalgia Print Club.

Their whimsical club names often have a story behind them. Soni, 24, says she picked the bovine name because "cows (moos) are slow, they have no urgency". The club mirrors that idea. "With the rise of AI, we are forgetting there's a real world out there. When the world gets too loud and chaotic, we go back to holding paper and appreciating the slow," she says. Moo Mail Club started in December 2025 with seven members. Today, Soni sends out 50-60 mails a month, each containing a letter, postcard, stickers, an art print or zine and an "unrot activity"—because, as she puts it, "how much phone can you really scroll?"

Goudet started Water Lilies, named after Claude Monet's famous work, in January with about six subscribers. She now has around 30 subscribers. One edition costs ₹450. For the 22-year-old, the appeal is part of

"Physical letters introduce a healthy friction. You have to wait for the post. You have to actually slow down"

MEGHA JEEVAN, The Scratching Post Mail Club, Goa



a larger generational shift. "Analogue media has been boiling over for the last two-three years, especially after Covid. People, especially the young, are starting to find solace in things that are not digitally native, like the physical or tangible connection that a letter provides," she says.

According to the youth market research firm YPulse's 2026 Tech/Device Usage survey in North America, 75% of 18-24-year-olds and 55% of 13-17-year-olds wanted to "go more analogue" and take up more offline hobbies.

Like the artists, most of the subscribers are young. The Whimsy Paint Mail Club, launched in March, charges ₹550 for each mail and largely draws art lovers between 20 and 35 years of age. Most of Jeevan's subscribers are also in their 20s and 30s across tier-I and -II cities.

PUSHING THE ENVELOPE

What makes them buy—art, the act of receiving a letter, nostalgia, novelty? Soni believes art is front and centre. "Art mail is quietly rewriting who gets to collect art. No gallery walls, no gatekeeping, no pretending you know enough about art to buy it. Just an envelope in your hands," she says. "It turns collecting into something intimate. Less transaction, more correspondence."

What you write matters too. Soni's letters are personal as if she is writing to a pen pal. "My members know when I travel, what's going on in my life. Some of them even write back." For Jeevan, the letter and the replies are the most loved part: "In this fleeting digital world, if someone takes the time to sit and write a mail, that exchange is pure magic for me."

That intimacy stops many from scaling up. Says Jeevan: "While bigger numbers look better, I really want to stay involved." She toyed with the idea of a digital mail but that would have defeated the purpose. "These physical letters introduce a healthy friction." Varsha says the letter is the main point. "This is more about the experience of receiving a beautifully crafted envelope, opening it slowly and discovering what's inside. That anticipation and sense of surprise are what subscribers enjoy the most." Along with a painting, she also gives a guide to share the joy she felt while painting. "Sharing that creative process is just as important as sharing the final artwork."

These artists are on Instagram and are aware of the contradiction at the heart of the model: to sell an escape from Instagram, they have to first feed it. Jeevan has to constantly make content to promote the mail club. Now, she is trying to take Scratching Post into cafes, co-working spaces and pop-ups.

For artists, the bigger question is how to keep it going. Next month, Thane-based artist Vedanti Shinde, 29, is discontinuing her mail club The Sleepy Cat Post, started eight months ago. She says, "When I started out, there weren't many art mail clubs. Now there's a surge and it feels a bit like a price war." She started the club to give herself a reason to make fresh art every month—and feels that newer opportunities have left her with less time to keep doing it. The medium also has its limits. "Properly communicating the quality of my work on Instagram requires more marketing and time. I don't think I can do justice to my club now," she says.

It is a tension other artists recognise. Goudet began Water Lilies partly to force herself to make art regularly after four years of studying computer science. She says art mail helps independent artists find an audience. "There's a rising trend of independent collectives



WHAT IS ART MAIL?

Independent artists mail subscribers a curated mix of original prints, postcards, stickers, bookmarks, zines or other paper collectibles. Takers are mostly Gen Z and younger millennials

WHY IS IT BACK?

- Screen fatigue and return to analogue hobbies
- Novelty meets nostalgia: for Gen Z, waiting for a letter feels old and new
- A low-entry way to own prints and collectibles
- Indie artists' connecting directly with followers

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(Clockwise from left) Art mail from The Scratching Post Club, Water Lilies and Moo Mail

and artists finding their voice and their tribe online. I think art mail, as one aspect of that growth, is an indicator of where we are headed in terms of a larger appreciation of homegrown and rooted brands."

For Soni, it has brought visibility as she was one of the featured artists on Adobe's website recently.

Jeevan says the analogue revival shouldn't be about yet another thing to buy. "I am unsure how much of this wave is genuine craving and how much of it is performance—something to do because our algorithms have told us this is the next thing to do."

The way out? You can write a letter—and wait for a reply. Until then, there's always some art mail. nupur.amarnath@timesofindia.com



STUDENTS REFLECT ON THEIR FUTURE AFTER ATTENDING A "CAREER DAY" AT THE JB PETIT HIGH SCHOOL FOR GIRLS, MUMBAI, IN AUGUST:

WHAT ARE YOU GONNA DO?

Zaynah Vasaiwala, Class X, JB Petit High School for Girls: I have two options—international law and cyber security. I would do cybersecurity because with all the data breaches due to AI, it would be in demand. I've tried my best to combine my passions with something logical.

IMAGES ARE AI-GENERATED AND REPRESENTATIONAL

Gowdesh Pati was horrified when her daughter wanted to drop biology in Class IX. She relented only when a psychometric test pointed out the child's interest was in literature and law. "AI was not a factor in decision-making. My guess is AI won't replace lawyers," says Pati.

FUTURE TENSE

A generation of teenagers are under real strain. Rayna Mehta, a clinical psychologist and school counsellor in Mumbai, says kids regularly tell her they are too young to know what they want. "It's a VUCA world—one of volatility, uncertainty, complexity and ambiguity. My suggestion to parents is: don't worry about aptitude. If your kid is interested, aptitude develops. But if your kid is not interested although they have a great talent in that area, they are not going to want to do it, because they are just not interested."

Arjun Vaidya, managing partner of V3 Ventures, says he no longer regrets not knowing how to code. The two skills he recommends are: some fluency in creating content and mid-level proficiency with LLMs.

Institutions are adapting unevenly. Bachwani says some colleges, sensing paren-

Validity of current courses might be only half a decade. I hope every parent and child realise there is no concept of completing one's education. You need to update yourself and move up the ladder"

SYED SULTAN AHMED, chairperson, The Association of International Schools of India

tal anxiety, are tying up with IT companies from the first year of engineering to place students and give them real-world exposure early. "Everybody is saying that 10 years from now we cannot imagine what job scenarios would be like. So what are we educating our children for? What is the basis of this curriculum design?" she asks. The big shift that is needed, she argues, is generational: parents should step back from their worldview and let children take risks. "Parents are not willing to take that risk. Even when students are stepping out of their comfort zone, parents are pulling them back."

Ahmed puts it more bluntly: planning too far ahead may be pointless. "The validity of current courses might be only half a decade. I hope every parent and every child understand that there is no concept of completing one's education. You need to upgrade yourself, update yourself and move up the ladder. No one's going to be in a job, doing the same thing in the same industry for 40 years. It's going to be like three to five years."

apoorva.mittal1@timesofindia.com



Flash flood, triggered by a glacial collapse on August 26, wreaked death and destruction in Nepal and Tibet



Heavy rains caused massive landslides in Meppadi in Wayanad in July 2024

Global Warning

From Nepal to Assam to Kerala, nature's fury is colliding with unchecked development

Alenjith K Johny

Over the last few years, Nepal's weather has become increasingly unfamiliar to those living there. The Himalayan nation has experienced weather events that were once unheard of, including the first tornado in the country's plains a few years ago.

All of this worries Sunil Acharya, an international climate policy and just transition specialist based in Kathmandu. It is not merely that extreme events are becoming more frequent, but that they are becoming harder to anticipate. Each new disaster seems to bring something Nepal has not dealt with before.

The latest: a glacial collapse triggering flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border, killing more than 1,200 people and leaving thousands missing.

The problem is not confined to Nepal. Chamoli district in Uttarakhand experienced a similar disaster when a glacier and bedrock collapse triggered a flood in 2021. Just this year, flash floods and landslides struck across India—from Assam and Uttarakhand to Kerala.

According to HydroSense Lab, a research facility in IIT-Delhi, India recorded nearly 2,000 such events between 2019 and 2023. The International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) says that studies point to an increase in reported flash floods since the 1990s.

While climate change is a major catalyst, the disasters unfolding across the region are also influenced by indiscriminate development in fragile mountain landscapes. For years, the debate has been framed as a choice between development and conservation. The human cost of that false binary is now becoming harder to ignore.

CRISIS TIME

Glacier-related floods are a particularly worrying sign of how quickly the risks are changing. Such events are occurring at shorter intervals across the Himalayan region.

In August, an ice patch weighing about 69 million kilos collapsed from the Srikanta Glacier in Uttarakhand's Garhwal Himalayas, according to a study published in *Natural Hazards*. The glacier sits at an altitude of about 5,220 m.

The Chamoli disaster was a grim warning when a large chunk of a Himalayan glacier collapsed in the district, sending debris and water downstream, killing about 200 people. Scientists later estimated the force of the collapse to be equivalent of roughly 15 atomic bombs.

The changing nature of the floods is only one part of the problem. The other is what has been built along the rivers.

"Often floodplain guidelines are not fully followed in hilly terrain," says Kapil Gupta, an IIT-Bombay professor who specialises in urban flood forecasting and mitigation. Local pressure, he says, often pushes construction closer to rivers.

India has guidelines to keep such construction away from flood-prone areas. The Central Water Commission guidelines propose a default 100 m restriction from the edge of a river until a state completes the scientific identification and demarcation of its floodplains.

The broader policy problem has been acknowledged by NITI Aayog, which has noted that human activity can substantially increase the severity of floods and has called for strict implementation of floodplain zoning. Whether this is happening on the ground is the big question.

As Sher Muhammad, a scientist at ICIMOD, points out, "In the Himalayas, we increasingly have to consider extreme rainfall together with glacier change, glacial lakes, unstable slopes, landslides and large sediment loads. At the same time, expansion of settlements, roads and hydropower infrastructure is increasing exposure in some already vulnerable valleys."

CONSTRUCTION GALORE

Many parts of the Himalayan region fall in highly vulnerable seismic zones, while construction has expanded rapidly.

Wetlands and floodplains are being lost. Forests are being cleared. Slopes are being cut for roads and other infrastructure. Construction can alter drainage and destabilise terrain. When extreme rainfall or a glacial event follows, the damage can be amplified by what is already on the ground.

The Char Dham road project in Uttarakhand was launched in 2016 to widen and upgrade about 889 km of highways to two-lane roads with paved shoulders, while adding tunnels, bypasses and other structures. In 2017, the Kargil-Zaskar Road was declared National Highway 301,



The Chamoli disaster of 2021 was a grim alert in the Himalayan region

opening a new phase of highway development in the Trans-Himalayan region.

Highway projects in Uttarakhand have continued to expand, with the government announcing and inaugurating multiple projects in 2024, including widening stretches in Rudrapur and Chamoli.

Better roads have opened remote parts of the Himalayas to tourists and pilgrims.

In the Himalayas, we have to consider extreme rainfall together with glacier change, glacial lakes, unstable slopes, landslides and large sediment loads. At the same time, expansion of settlements, roads and hydropower infrastructure is increasing exposure in some already vulnerable valleys"

SHER MUHAMMAD, remote sensing specialist, ICIMOD

Sikkim and Uttarakhand, with a financial outlay of ₹150 crore. The Central Water Commission also monitors glacial lakes across the Himalayan river basins using remote sensing techniques.

But is that enough for these new challenges? In a conventional flood, water levels rise gradually. Monitoring stations can detect the change and send an alert before the water reaches communities. The recent Nepal event was different.

"This time, the size of the ice mass was so enormous that by the time it hit the ground, it released a huge amount of energy," says Acharya. "Even before these stations could send triggers, the flow moved much quicker."

Some of the monitoring systems were washed away. That raises a question beyond alerts: where do people go when it arrives?

"People talk a lot about early warning systems," says Gupta. "But if you don't know the drill to shift a person to a safe shelter during a catastrophic event, it is going to become harder to manage."

The question, he says, is what comes after the warning. "Where is that safe place? How many people can be saved?"

DISASTER WITHOUT BORDERS

The Himalayas span across Nepal, India,

"Consumers are using different frames for different occasions, times of day and moods," says Sheth. "There is a growing feeling that you don't need one pair of glasses to do everything."

EYE CANDY

That is turning eyewear into something closer to a wardrobe than a prescription purchase. "Consumers are building an eyewear wardrobe that works across different aspects of their lifestyle," says Emma Lithander, head of merchandising, John Jacobs. "Refined shapes, a modern design language, bolder silhouettes and unexpected colours allow consumers to express their style while maintaining a polished, versatile look."

The biggest indicator of this is multiple purchases. When eyewear was viewed primarily as a functional product, people looked for one pair that worked for everything. Today, consumers are buying different frames for different outfits and occasions.

Dayal Opticals is seeing the same pattern. "There is a rise in multi-pair ownership, customers buying separate frames for work, weekends and even seasonal rotation," says Kalra. "This behaviour is a clear indicator that eyewear has moved beyond function to

Customers are not buying eyewear purely for utility; they are engaging with it as a style decision, which is a clear departure from the past"

SARVASH KALRA, director, Dayal Opticals

The 35+ customer is fashion-savvy and not afraid to go beyond traditional frame colours like black and brown, and rimless eyewear. They are no longer seeking frames appropriate to their age but frames that reflect their personalities and lifestyles"

PRITYANKA GUPTA, director, GKB Opticals

become an integral part of one's fashion vocabulary."

Gupta of GKB Opticals agrees. "A sign that people view eyewear as a fashion accessory is that many own multiple pairs of eyeglasses, with one being conservative enough for office, while the other serves a more stylish purpose," she says.

What changed? For one, the office itself. The post-pandemic workplace is less rigid about personal expression, while social media has made eyewear trends considerably harder to ignore. Kalra says, "Eyewear today operates in a far more visible and discussed space, largely driven by social media, which has made consumers more aware and open to experimentation in a category that was once approached conservatively." He also points to an unlikely catalyst: masks. "During the pandemic years of mask usage, attention was drawn to the upper half of the face. That heightened focus has persisted, leading many customers to approach eyewear as a more deliberate and expressive choice than before."

Gupta attributes the shift to a combination of influences: "The development is due to social media, celebrities'

Glasses with bold frames have emerged as a form of self-expression for professionals who traditionally relied on luxury watches, silk ties, or fine jewellery"

AMARBIR SINGH, India head, Kering Eyewear

and influencers' styles, changes in office environment and international fashion influences." Perhaps the biggest change is psychological. "What matters most is that people view eyewear as an addition to their style."

Singh puts it more bluntly: "Older consumers are adopting styles traditionally associated with younger shoppers, as no one wants to look old." He says the trend is fuelled by "higher discretionary income, changing mindset on ageing and the influence of 'silver influencers'." The result is a new kind of workplace accessory: You can keep it classic or you can let your frames do the talking.

glynda.alves@timesofindia.com

Glynda Alves

In the new workplace wardrobe, the tie is vanishing—that flash of colour that could showcase your mood, your hobbies and, on a Friday, even the cartoon character you liked. So what takes its place? Socks are good, but only a sliver is visible; watches are expected but tend to signal status rather than personality; and jewellery can feel fussy. Enter the once-discreet frames. If eyes are the windows to the soul, frames are the curtains—and the latest workplace ones are anything but beige.

"Glasses with bold and distinctive frames have firmly established themselves as the ultimate professional power accessory, emerging as a form of self-expression for mature professionals who traditionally relied on luxury watches, silk ties, or fine jewellery," says Amarbir Singh, India head, Kering Eyewear.

Retailers are happy about the shift. "Frames are worn throughout the day and are far more visible, making it a natural medium for personal expression," says Sarvash Kalra, director, Dayal Opticals. He adds that professionals in their late 30s to 50s now approach frames with the same intent once reserved for a fine watch. "The frames are reflective of personal taste, while still operating within a largely restrained overall look."

Once rimless and barely there frames were the workplace uniform. Not anymore. Eyewear in 2026 is all about considered impact—stronger shapes, refined colours and a sharper take on familiar classics. Styles that do well include sculptural acetate with thick carved frames and structured metal frames with angular bridges and



Hall of Frame

Glasses with bold and distinctive frames are the new corporate accessory

squared lenses. While quiet neutrals such as champagne, caramel and smoke keep frames understated, there has been a shift toward green, navy, oxblood and burgundy.

Ronak Sheth, founder of Opium Eyewear, says professionals are ditching the discreet look in favour of frames with attitude. "Customers are looking for brighter colours, stronger silhouettes and more distinctive frames, rather than defaulting to simple, understated styles. Even when they aren't toting for colour, there is a

Customers are looking for brighter colours, stronger silhouettes and more distinctive frames. There is a definite preference for thicker, more substantial acetate frames that make a statement"

RONAK SHETH, founder, Opium Eyewear

definite preference for thicker, more substantial acetate frames that make a statement," he says.

SPECS APPEAL

At GKB Opticals, customers over 35 years account for about 70% of clientele. "And the 35+ customer is fashion-savvy and not afraid to go beyond traditional colours like black and brown, and rimless eyewear," says Priyanka Gupta, director, GKB Opticals. "They are no longer seeking frames appropriate to their

age but frames that reflect their personalities and lifestyles."

Dayal Opticals is seeing a similar shift. "Older consumers are becoming more experimental. Customers who bought safe, understated frames are now exploring colours, textures and new silhouettes," says Kalra. "They are no longer buying purely for utility; they are engaging with eyewear as a style decision, which marks a clear departure from past behaviour."

The change, says Sheth, is not about older consumers trying to look younger; they are just dropping the idea that certain styles belong to certain age groups. "The distinction between what is considered 'young' and 'old' eyewear is becoming less rigid," he says.

Perhaps the biggest change is not just what frames people are buying, but how many they are buying.



Why Footpaths in This Country Are Not Paved with the Best of Intentions

With sidewalks mostly a theoretical concept in our cities, pedestrian culture is very, well, pedestrian, while walking itself is déclass , which is a pity since that’s from where most of life is reliably observed

ON THE LEDGE



PALASH KRISHNA MEHROTRA

The Supreme Court recently declared the right to walk on demarcated footpaths a fundamental right. Justice PV Narsimha wrote, ‘The absence of footpaths to walk on, and even when they exist, their subjugation to motor transport, has been a civilisational problem.’ The funda is solid, no doubt. But we Indians are sceptical of the gap that exists between normative ideal and ground reality. One hopes we can walk the talk.

I’ve been hit twice from behind, once by a

motorcycle and another time by an autorickshaw. Both times, the pavement was absent. I’d like to extend the right to pavements to the right to cross the road. When I first went to England, I was surprised to find that there exists something called the pedestrian’s right-of-way. Indian pavements, where they exist, become urinals, or they’re turned into a parking lot. During peak traffic hours, 2-wheelers use them as a road to get ahead of traffic snarls. Our pavements are great at multitasking.

I live in Dehradun. It has narrow roads. Most pavements are at the same level as the street, offering no protection. Recently, at the beginning of monsoon, the municipality thoughtfully installed a series of rumble strips on potholed roads, missing the point that concave crater-like potholes already, inadvertently, serve the role of convex rumble strips. SUVs are built to absorb the impact of potholes, but they still end up swerving on to the pavement because they want to avoid the bump.

When crossing a road, many thoughts



PATHBREAKING

cross the pedestrian’s mind as she waits for that tiny opening, the brief window of opportunity in which to scurry, make the Usain Boltian dash. I tend to lurk on the kerb for the longest time, waiting for the traffic to thin. In my head, I’m playing a Test match. One has to let a lot of balls go. There will be a period of play when the runs will come—that is, when one can run across.

I’m amazed by skilful street dogs that scamper across with practised ease. At times, the dog goes over, says hello to his pal, and returns to my side of the road. In that embarrassing moment, I realise that the time has come to take the plunge. It’s

There is a class element to walking in India. In Delhi, walking is an activity meant for the domestic help and dogs

now or never. If dogs can do it...

There is a class element to walking in India. You stop walking the moment you buy a vehicle. It’s considered déclass  to walk. In cities like Delhi, walking is an activity meant for the domestic help and dogs, more specifically for domestic helps walking the dog. The sahib and memsahib will walk on a walking path in the park, but not the street.

I like walking. One can stop and admire a tree, take in hoardings and signboards, stop for a corn-on-the-cob; gently bump into people, for Indians have this funny habit of abruptly stopping dead in their tracks to check something on the phone. One can catch snippets of overheard conversation from passers-by.

I’ve witnessed scenes of petty violence: a woman whacking an ‘eve-teaser’ with her chappal, a bunch of students beating up another student over some quarrel; a man

blaming a girl over a failed attempt at picking his pocket. In a moving vehicle, life passes you by. When you’re walking, you can stand still and observe life.

The pace at which one walks reflects the pace of the city one is in. Once in Mumbai, I was walking briskly at night, in a hurry to get to my grandparents’ place. A disembodied voice rose from dark: ‘Aaram se chalo. Ab raat ho gayi hai!’ I slowed down on hearing the friendly command.

In the monsoon, our roads tend to disappear. The other day, news came of pedestrians using barricades with wheels to cross a flooded road in Gurugram. A section of the Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway sank following heavy rain. For there to be pavements, we need roads in the first place. We might come across a situation in the future when the pavement remains, but the road has vanished. That will be poetic justice for pedestrians.

JUGULAR VEIN



JUG SURAIYA

Working Naam Ke Vaaste on Benami Dealings

What’s in a name? Ask Friedrich Drumpf’s name-dropping grandson

Asking what was in a name, Juliet sighed on her balcony that a rose by any other name would smell as sweet. By which she dismissed the nominal basis of identity, a declaration to which Gertrude Stein would add the tautological postscript in her 1913 poem, ‘Sacred Emily,’ that ‘a rose is a rose is a rose’, a reiteration Umberto Eco echoed in the concluding Latin epigram of his 1980 novel, The Name of the Rose: ‘Stat rosa pristina nomine, nomina nuda tenemus’—the pristine rose remains only in name, we are left only with naked names.

Confronted with such flowery verbiage, the current tenant of the White House might mistake the rosy-eyed Juliet with Juliet Huddy, an ex-Fox News anchor, who alleged that POTUS had made osculatory contact with her in an elevator, and conflate Gertrude Eco into a portmanteau illegal immigrant, who should be ICE-d.

Such wars of the roses have topical relevance and resonate with headlines inspired by Donald Trump’s baptismal binge of renaming geographical features to fit his fancy.

In what might be called nominal neo-colonisation, the MAGAmaniacal occupier of the Oval Office unleashed a terminological tour de force by renaming the Gulf of Mexico the ‘Gulf of America’ and, as a follow-up, rechristening Lake Ontario as ‘Lake America’. This, in the context of the ongoing tariff tangles with the US’ northern neighbour, might be interpreted as a curtain-raiser for a territorial takeover, which would make Canada the 51st state of the US—or the You Yes of Aye, as in You say Yes when I say Aye.

Far from pouring Texas oil on troubled waters, POTUS has gone on to moot an onomastic sea change for both the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans.

Sticks and stones may break my bones, but words will never hurt me, goes the old children’s rhyme. However, as conventions and credos as diverse as international law, numerology, and superstitious belief would have it, monikers possess mojo.

Namesmanship is gamesmanship by another location regarding location. It is seen as an underhanded undermining of national sovereignty, be it the Gulf between Mexico and the US—‘Poor Mexico, so close to the US and so far from god,’ as former president Porfirio Diaz of the Amigo Country lamented—or the Lake of Lacuna between Washington DC and Ottawa PO (PO standing for Pissed Off).

Closer to home, New Delhi’s dudgeon is high over the sneaky Chinese titular takeaway of Arunachal Pradesh by calling it ‘Zangnam’ (Southern Tibet). MEA is pulling no punches in letting Beijing know that that’s not the way for the fortune cookie to crumble, not for all the chai in Chini—the Hindi name for China—notwithstanding all the sweet talk at next weekend’s BRICS summit.

That names can literally cast a spell on one is central to numerology, the crypto-science which ascribes numeric values to letters of the alphabet, which, when totted up, arrive at a figure deemed to be either lucky or otherwise.

If the sum arrived at is unfavourable, extra consonants or vowels, or both, are appended to the name until—Abracadabra!—alphabetical arithmetic arrives at the magical password which will open portals of fame, fortune, and green card, even if by now the auspicious appellation resembles the verbal version of a corkscrew defying articulation by even such an epitome of elocution as Harivansh Rai Bachchan.

In diverse cultures and climes, names are believed to have mystical essence, knowledge of which would give ill-wishers power over one. Such a belief has resulted in the disguise of a true name known only to the family and a closed circle of intimates, cloaked by a surrogate designation for the outside, and possibly inimical, world.

Trump himself has a legacy of a name change in that his German immigrant paternal grandfather, Friedrich Drumpf, morphed into the anglophone-friendly ‘Trump’ as being a more winsome handle, if not a winning hand. Is POTUS’ proclivity for the ledger-dominant of labelling an atavistic throwback to such Drumperie?

Whatever be his motivation, the prez presses on with his epithetical enthusiasms, even if they are seen to be naam ke vaaste exercises, revealing him to be just another benami guy.

BETWEEN BEGGING & BELLIGERENCE

In our dealings with customer service, these two tactics lie at either end of the ‘getting things done’ spectrum

WORD COUNTS



TUSHAR GORE

One of the most essential life skills is the ability to persuade someone to do something that has a favourable outcome for ourselves. There is sophisticated psychology at work here. What is the incentive for the other person to do this activity? A cynical view that individuals are fundamentally self-centered and will act only in self-interest will inevitably condemn us to search for some leverage before interacting with anyone.

Fortunately, most humans do behave with a basic sense of decency—probably the source of clich s like ‘faith in humanity’—and in most instances will accommodate others’ needs and perform activities to benefit others. And, as with any population statistic, there is a spread for the ‘helpfulness’ index of individuals.

But if helping others is in the job description, then individuals in customer service should not be faced with any philosophical dilemma regarding whether to help. They are required to do this. Simple.

Yet, in our dealings with customer service, often there is frustration that instead of service we get short-changed, and customer care has to be interpreted as customer beware. Raised voices in

varied settings such as banks, shopping malls, hotels and hospitals are a frequent reminder that the customer service pact has broken down.

This column isn’t about the root causes of these inefficiencies, but rather about the tools available to us to persuade service professionals and secure a favourable outcome. How do we accomplish this when we are interacting for the first time with a person, and that too only for a matter of minutes?

The most cited research on persuasion is by psychologist Robert Cialdini. A partial list of dimensions—tactics that be used to persuade someone—includes:

- Reciprocity: because it requires a give and take.
- Commitment: because of a prior similar act or a promise.
- Social proof and acceptance: because everyone else does it.
- Authority: acting because of someone’s command.
- Liking: because the act is for a ‘likeable’ person.

Many of these tools require that the two individuals share several interactions and have substantial time for discussions. Real-life situations don’t permit such extended dialogues. Even the most basic form of the reciprocity tactic, a tip, is possible only in certain instances, and that too not over the phone.

My experience is that routinely, the interaction is a see-saw between two tactics that are not named explicitly in the list: begging and belligerence. First ask politely, and even suppliantly. If that fails, or is taken as a sign of weakness,

Raised voices are a frequent reminder that the customer service pact has broken down



BEAN THERE, DONE THAT

TAP INTO THIS NEW BREED OF ENDORSERS

You see them advertising everywhere, so why not your products and services?

RED HERRING



INDRAJIT HAZRA

Like the sniveling boy in M Night Shyamalan’s 1999 psychological thriller, The Sixth Sense, who sees dead people, I see politicians. Since you, too, can see a politician when his or her image appears on your screen or in a newspaper, let me rephrase: I see politicians everywhere.

The other day, while looking out of the car window, I glanced at a roadside poster advertising a jewellery brand. And there he was—a politician in white kurta, hands folded into a namaskar, wordlessly inviting me to drop by and perhaps pick up a ‘nature-inspired gold jewellery set with floral and leafy motifs’ in case I fancy that kind of thing. On closer inspection, however, I realised that the man was the owner of a jewellery chain, not some neta.

This, by itself, was rare. Hardly any owner advertises his or her own products, or services, at least in this country. I’m unlikely to ever see Mukesh Ambani come on an advert and tell us, ‘Visit your nearest Reliance Fresh today. Because sabzi is the new oil.’ Or Sunil Bharti Mittal looking down from a billboard, making a ‘Call me’ sign with his hand, with the tagline: ‘Network chorhiye, networth banaaiye!’ Vijay Mallya may have been largely responsible for inadvertently nipping a possible owner-endorser trend in the bud.

Celebrities, led by actors, have been the big-ticket models for big-ticket products and services. Salman Khan was briefly successful in convincing me to change my underwear with his ‘Yeh aaram

ka mamla hai’ line for Rupa Frontline. But, frankly, I wasn’t that much in-vested in the brand.

Professional models, of course, still make a profession of modelling for products and services. But if you think about it (read: aren’t blind), the most visible brand ambassadors are politicians in this country. Open any newspaper, and if you go simply by the maximum number of people from any profession appearing in them, you will find them to be from the world’s second-oldest profession. Depending on which state you live in, local leaders will also feature on a regular basis, along with national ones, as a visual stamp by association with some official scheme, event, or engagement being advertised.

For those familiar with the outdoors, posters, handbills, and billboards will display their sanction and blessing for anything from a political rally to a social calendar event. What they are endorsing, of course, is the bundled product-service of their party. And if they’re lucky to have won an election to form a government, their govern-

ment. But the real big guys—PMs and CMs—lend their visual heft to more than just party or governmentally fitting things.

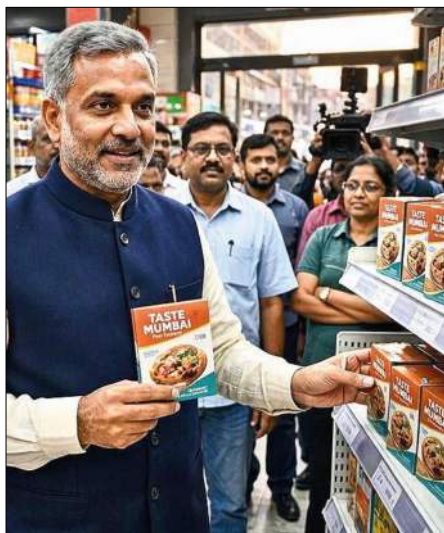
During the 2017 Fifa Under-17 World Cup in Kolkata—where I saw England’s Phil Foden score two goals in the final against Spain, a month before the midfielder joined Manchester City, where he still plays at the grand age of 26—the roads leading up to Salt Lake Stadium, and at the stadium itself, were festooned with banners, posters, signboards proclaiming the tournament and the grand finale.

And whose image went with every U-17 World Cup banner, poster, signboard? Star striker Mamata Banerjee’s, of course.

Whenever there is a returning hero from any international award ceremony, competition, or tournament, the protagonist in the ‘vijay jhandas’ and miscellaneous banners is almost always the neta, not the winning individual or team. It is, one supposes, the politician’s sub kamma and support that must have led to such a moment of pride. And many times, to bask in the light of the supreme leader, other leaders join in as smaller cut-outs to share in the influence—that tell the onlooker: ‘I, too, have played a small part.’

So, think about it. Let politicians—universally adored and believed—endorse your business, product, or service by simply ‘appearing’ in adverts. In exchange of some material support for the party, and some cross-endorsement, your namkeen, movie, or skincare product, can do with a politician’s visual advocacy.

It’s a whole group of influencers to be tapped. After some initial resistance—‘My picture in a Hotel Hindustan International New Year’s Eve Countdown Night promotional with DJ Bunchiki Bumbum?’—surely they will shake off their legendary shyness.



INFLUENTIAL PEOPLE

indrajit.hazra@timesofindia.com

NO OFFENCE Morparia

HUMANOID ROBOT BREAKS USAIN BOLT’S RECORD

©Morparia

ET Sunday Crossword 0184

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32

ACROSS

1 Purchase yearbook by phone every six months (8)

5 Graduate cuts bread in N. African enclave (6)

9 Peg keeps rag ends over in lab container (4,4)

10 Second husband (Irish) consumes a goat product (6)

12 30 eating popular pig product (4)

13 Keats drank bubbly in the buff (5-5)

15 In no time, Paul’s crudely spread this on wall (8,5)

19 Bitterly disappointed but OK? (6-7)

23 Make changes to English instrument

during upturn (10)

25 Become engaged during game show (4)

28 Imagine somehow not having a single puzzle! (6)

29 Downgrade top envoy after start of reunion (8)

30 Fair to be arranged when approval comes round (3,3)

31 Baroque tea-set impresses man, one with refined tastes (8)

DOWN

1 Make fast driver (6)

2 Churchman doesn’t start lighting fires (5)

3 Crazy students welcome beginning of term (4)

4 A murderer in Rome raising rare shrub (7)

6 American navy maintains firm bit of mast (5)

7 Former empire tailing Boycott’s visitor in garden (9)

8 In Darwin’s study he tried untangling end of story (8)

11 Threesome tang at port (4)

14 French minister’s remedy (4)

15 He studies monies flowing around business on time (9)

16 Eire conceded territory, causing fury (3)

17 Shame it’s controlled by party extremists (4)

18 Deer managed to invade a Scottish peak—near here? (8)

20 A bit of a yarn for Henry, as he’s known in LA (4)

21 An American tree disturbed grave (7)

22 Clever plan to identify sign of asthma (6)

24 Letter for Athenian schoolmaster (5)

26 Scrub contribution to opera season (5)

27 Start and finish of zeitgeist evoked piquancy (4)

27 Zest.
22 Whence; 24 Gamma; 26 Erase.
12 Whence; 24 Gamma; 26 Erase.
11 Threesome tang at port (4)
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26 Scrub contribution to opera season (5)
27 Start and finish of zeitgeist evoked piquancy (4)

LET’S TALK ABOUT...

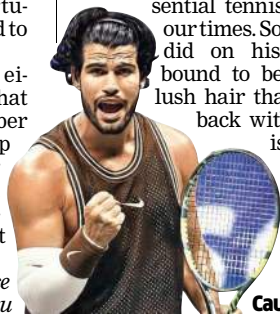


Nip-caraz

Vamos! Alcaraz is back on the court, the first time in over four months after his wrist injury. And the US Open just got more interesting. Yes, it seems the tennis fans were waiting to see him in action. But people were hoping they’d see a little less of him.

Whatever do you mean? Well, his new Nike X Cactus Jack (Travis Scott’s streetwear brand) kit is being lauded for its chocolate brown ombre hues which he has carried through to the second round, but it has one issue: the deep cut of the shirt. While playing, it has led to a lot of nip-slips with the internet branding him ‘Nip-caraz’.

Whoa! People have too much time. Well, people do but also fans were waiting for his comeback. For tennis fans it’s like missing the ye old Becker-Bjorg days or Nadal-Federer face-offs. Sin-Caraz are the quintessential tennis bete noir of our times. So everything he did on his return was bound to be noticed. His lush hair that he’s pulling back with a headband is the talk of the tourney. But the ‘free the nipple’ vibe of his kit has caught on.



Caught on...how? Reddit, X,

Threads and Instagram accounts are busy clocking Nip-caraz moments. An Instagram account posted a reel with the title ‘POV: Alcaraz X Travis Scott collab is fire but the nipple got its own contract’, while Redditors are discussing the kit on channels where one commented that the cut of the vest is a basketball cut, which streetwear is inspired from, and not suited for tennis where the arms move differently. On Threads, someone started a photo album of his ‘beautiful hair and nip slips’.

Fans! (shakes head) Am I right? Well, the nip slips are distracting and many are wondering if Alcaraz is bothered by it. They are also unhappy with Nike. Fans are agreeing that they ‘could have done without the nips’. They feel the outfit is more focused on hypebeast fashion than actual athletic functionality.

But he’s back in business. Well, we are here for it. Though ‘there’s many a slip twixt cup and lip’, but us fans just wish the slips were not of the ‘nip’ variety. Text: Nupur Amarnath

PUTIN'S SPOKESPERSON SAYS KUSHNER, WITKOFF TO MEET RUSSIAN LEADER ‘No talk of new ideas’

US Envoys in Moscow, Putin Halts Kyiv Strikes for 72 Hrs

Russian President Vladimir Putin ordered a 72-hour pause in strikes on Kyiv, the Kremlin said Saturday, as US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner arrived in Moscow to try to revive a stalled push to end Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

“Putin has ordered that no strikes be carried out against Kyiv for three days, starting at midnight today,” presidential spokesperson Dmitry Peskov told Russia's *Tass* news agency. He said the decision was tied to preparations for Witkoff and Kushner's planned visit to the Ukrainian capital, which Kyiv has said will happen Sunday.

Peskov also confirmed that Kushner and Witkoff would meet Putin during their visit, but said there was “no talk of new ideas” to end the conflict. The envoys' trip comes as both sides escalate aerial attacks, some four-and-a-half years after the Kremlin's invasion of its neighbour.

ZELENSKY SPEAKS TO ENVOYS

Meanwhile, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he spoke with Witkoff and Kushner, adding that Kyiv was ready to refrain from strikes on Moscow from now on, and also on Sunday and Monday. He said he expected Russia to do the same regarding Ukraine.

“I have just spoken with the US President's envoys,” Zelenskyy said on Telegram. “From the moment of this conversation, we are ready to observe a ceasefire in airstrikes against the cities involved in the negotiation process.”

Washington's push to end the fighting, now in its fifth year, has lost momentum as US attention has been focused for the past six months on its war with Iran. The last known visit to Moscow by Witkoff and Kushner, Trump's son-in-law, was in January, when they met Putin in the Kremlin. They have never previously visited Kyiv.



Russia's presidential envoy Kirill Dmitriev (centre) welcomes US special envoy Steve Witkoff (right) and US President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner (left) at Vnukovo International Airport in Moscow AFP

The envoys were met at the airport in Moscow by Russian envoy Kirill Dmitriev, *Tass* reported. Dmitriev shared photos of him meeting them as they disembarked, alongside the caption, “Welcome to Moscow Peacemakers.”

With peace efforts stalled, Russia has intensified its attacks on Kyiv and other cities with relentless bombardments recently stretching into daylight hours, taking advantage of Ukraine's shortage of air defensive systems.

On Friday, a Russian drone hit one of the most important government buildings in Kyiv — the headquarters of Ukraine's Security Service, known as the SBU, which is one of the agencies involved in carrying out deep-strike operations inside Russia.

The long-range strikes by Ukraine have hit Russian military facilities, oil refineries and e-commerce hubs, seeking to undermine the Kremlin's war effort and economy, as well as make ordinary citizens feel the consequences of the war.

The air war between Russia and Ukraine has intensified as troops

have struggled to make progress along the 1,250-kilometer (775-mile) front line. Russia has recently been using fast-flying, jet-powered drones, and the recurring wail of air-raid sirens has become part of daily life in Kyiv.

In a social media post on Saturday, Zelenskyy said that Russia had carried out overnight strikes on Kyiv and Boryspil international airports, and linked the attack to the planned US visit.

“Clearly, these Russian strikes on the airports are a reaction to the discussions and preparations for the possibility of the US side using an aircraft to travel to Ukraine,” he said. “We have taken note of this Russian move, and next week we will adjust our operation accordingly regarding Russian airspace, which has become dangerous because of our drones and missiles in the sky. Of course, there are and will be no threats to diplomacy from our side.”

FIVE KILLED AT INDUSTRIAL SITE

Meanwhile, Russian attacks killed five people and wounded five more

ON CEASEFIRE

I have just spoken with the US President's envoys. From the moment of this conversation, we are ready to observe a ceasefire in airstrikes against the cities involved in the negotiation process.

VOLODYMYR ZELENSKY
President, Ukraine

at an industrial facility in Ukraine's southern Dnipropetrovsk region, local military administration head Oleksandr Hanzha said. He described those killed as employees at the site. “A locksmith, an electrician, a plumber and a machinist. People of peaceful professions. They were simply working their shift. They were doing their job when enemy missiles cut off their lives,” he said.

A 62-year-old man was wounded and several homes were damaged in a separate attack on the region's Nikopol district, Hanzha said.

In a statement Saturday, Russia's defence ministry said it had carried out strikes on two metallurgical plants in the region, describing them as “major suppliers of metal products for Ukraine's military production.” A further two people were wounded in an overnight Russian attack on Ukraine's Kyiv region, said Tymur Tkachenko, head of the regional military administration. In the Boryspil district, a fire sparked by a strike partially destroyed a nine-store residential building. **AP & Reuters**

Its Navy Warships ‘Targeted’, US Hits 3 Iranian Oil Tankers

Iranian TV reported the incident off Kharg island hours earlier

Cairo: The United States military on Saturday said it struck three Iranian oil tankers after Navy warships were targeted with missiles, warning that it would “if necessary, destroy Iran's limited and exposed oil fleet.”

The strikes—a day after President Donald Trump sought to minimize the conflict as “small potatoes”—keep up a new tilt back toward fighting after six months of on-again, off-again war that began with US and Israeli attacks on February 28. Both sides have sought to inflict both military and economic pain, and negotiations have collapsed. The military's statement said a US aircraft carrier and a destroyer evaded “multiple unprompted Iranian attacks” while patrolling in the region and no US personnel were hurt. It said two Iranian oil carriers were “permanently disabled” and the third, unladen one, was destroyed.

‘PART OF SHADOW NETWORK’

The US statement said the tankers were part of a shadow network helping to fund Iran's powerful Revolutionary Guard and its armed proxies in the region.

Earlier, Iranian state TV had said four US missiles struck a tanker about six miles (10 kilometers) from Kharg Island, home to a terminal through which the country exports most of its oil. Kharg Island has been repeatedly targeted during the war, including US strikes on military sites there in March.

The US said one tanker was struck off Kharg Island and another was struck near Jask, east of the Strait of Hormuz. The unladen tanker was hit in the Gulf of Oman. The statement shared what it called video footage of the strikes.

“We will not hesitate to defend American forces, and if necessary, destroy Iran's limited and exposed



A screenshot from footage released by the US Central Command shows what it says is a US strike on an Iranian crude oil tanker in the Gulf of Oman AFP

oil fleet,” said Admiral Brad Cooper, head of US Central Command.

WEEK AFTER FIGHTING RESUMED

The strikes came nearly a week after the US and Iran resumed attacks following a month of relative calm, with the strait and Iranian communities along it again being targeted. At least five people were killed earlier in the week during a US bombardment of southern Iran. One strike hit a wedding. The resumption of fighting came after new US efforts to apply economic pressures on Tehran, whose hard-line new senior leaders have signaled the willingness to dig in after weathering decades of sanctions.

Meanwhile, the issue that helped lead to the war—Iran's nuclear programme—was meant to be addressed in negotiations that fell apart soon after the US and Iran signed a memorandum of understanding in mid-June. Instead, Tehran's new leverage focuses on the strait that is crucial to global oil and natural gas shipments and was seen as an international waterway before the war began. The US military has been helping to guide ships through the strait as Tehran asserts control and targets some vessels, but overall traffic remains low. **AP**

Fresh Yemen Clashes Kill More than 60

Fighting between Yemen's Saudi-backed government forces and the country's Houthi rebels killed more than 60 people on Saturday, including civilians, medical and military sources told AFP.

The renewed clashes in Yemen's southwest over control of a gateway to the Red Sea came after Friday saw some of the deadliest fighting in years, following the collapse in July of a 2022 truce.

As per three Yemeni military sources, 26 government troops were killed during fighting in the country's southwest, while medical and military sources from the Iran-backed Houthis said 31 rebel fighters were killed.

One medical source in the government-held city of Taiz said a missile strike also killed six civilians travelling by bus and wounded seven others. A government official blamed the strike on the bus, travelling between Taiz and the seat of Yemen's internationally recognised government in Aden, on the Houthis. **AFP**

Govt Officials Also Under Lens

►► From Page 1

The FIR invoked Section 120B, read with sections 409 and 420 of the Indian Penal Code as well as provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act.

Both CBI and ED are likely to soon issue summonses to the accused for questioning. Among the nine accused booked by CBI are “unknown others and unknown public servants.”

Chandra denied having the net worth reflected in the certificates earlier submitted to LIC Housing Finance. It further said he claimed his net worth in 2024 was ₹31.79 crore, and that it had not exceeded ₹40.00 crore even in 2017-18.

LICHFL made the contradiction a key element of its criminal complaint, alleging that documents showing a substantially higher net worth were submitted to induce the lender to loan.

One credit facility of ₹500 crore was extended to Vasant Sagar Properties Pvt Ltd, with Pan India Infra Projects Pvt Ltd as co-borrower. The facility was described as a take-over, and a top-up loan for business expansion was backed by a continuing personal guarantee executed by Chandra on March 28, 2018.

The second facility, amounting to ₹480 crore, was extended to Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd, with Spirit Infrapower and Multiventures Pvt Ltd as co-borrowers, under a rental-discounting arrangement. Chandra ex-

SUMMONS SOON

Among the 9 accused booked by CBI are “unknown others and unknown public servants”

ecuted the continuing guarantee for this facility on August 10, 2018. Both accounts subsequently went into default, according to the complaint submitted to CBI.

The complaint said Chandra and the borrower companies acted in collusion and that the loan funds were misapplied. It further claimed that assets were stripped or otherwise dealt with in a manner that sought to frustrate the lender's ability to recover its dues. The criminal case has been filed at a time when LIC Housing Finance also figures among the major creditors in Chandra's ongoing personal insolvency proceedings. The company has an admitted claim of about ₹1,322.39 crore against Chandra in those proceedings.

A repayment plan associated with the insolvency process had proposed payment of only about ₹38.09 lakh to the housing finance company, triggering opposition from LICHFL and other creditors. The insolvency proceedings have separately been a matter of litigation before the National Company Law Tribunal.

The complaint emphasised a significant flight risk, stating that the accused persons had publicly disclosed their intention to leave India. LICHFL urged immediate action to trace the proceeds of the loans and prevent their departure. Consequently, CBI registered a regular case to initiate a formal criminal investigation under stringent legal provisions.

Flexible Supply Chain

►► From Page 1

“With EV demand concentrated in select states, and food inflation and uneven rainfall potentially affecting purchasing power, getting the product mix right could be critical this festive season,” said a senior official at a two-wheeler company.

Concerns around deficient rainfall, agricultural output and food inflation could weigh on rural purchasing power in the second half, with entry-level two-wheelers potentially more exposed given their dependence on rural demand.

However, these remain downside risks rather than evidence that two-wheeler sales will decline this festive season, industry experts said.

Hero MotoCorp, reporting its August performance this week, said domestic internal-combustion-engine retail grew 18% and pointed to a more flexible supply-chain ecosystem that enables quick response to festive demand.

“We often talk about rural India as one market,” said Ra-

vi Bhatia, president, JATO Dynamics India.

“In Rajasthan, the small commuter motorcycle dominates. Maharashtra has a much wider product mix. Ahead of the festive season, the question for manufacturers is not only how much rural demand there will be, but whether they have the right product in the right place,” he added.

ANALYSING TRENDS

With multiple variants, colours and very diverse customer preferences across rural markets, having the perfect product mix at every dealership is nearly impossible.

However, according to leading automotive dealer Vinod Gulati, “OEMs and dealers plan inventory by analysing the previous three months' sales trends, regional preferences and anticipated festive demand. Despite these challenges, a well-planned OEM with a strong understanding of its markets can still achieve around 80-85% accuracy in providing dealers with the right product

and inventory mix.”

EVs accounted for only 5.9% of rural registrations, roughly half their penetration in urban and metro markets.

Yet, rural EV demand is geographically concentrated, with Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh together accounting for more than 60% of rural EV registrations. This adds another layer to the stocking challenge.

Dealers expect the market to grow in the second half, though at a slower pace than in the first half.

“Despite external risk factors such as rising food inflation and uneven rainfall, OEMs are very sensitive to the requirements of dealers in different markets and dispatches are done accordingly,” said Sai Giridhar, president, FADA.

For manufacturers, the festive-season challenge is therefore not simply how much rural India will buy, but whether they have the right two-wheeler in the right market when demand peaks.

Mention Total Amount, Not Part Added

►► From Page 1

This was a rejoinder filed in the SC on September 5, in response to FSSAI's affidavit. The petitioner sought implementation of the warning labels in a single all-encompassing phase rather than leaving products high in only one nutrient to a second stage in the future, or to set a definite timeline for starting the second phase.

“The proposed introduction of phase II without prescribing any definite or binding timeline renders the proposed regulatory framework susceptible to indefinite postponement and defeats the very purpose of phased implementation,” said the filing.

After a decade-long delay, FSSAI, after getting pulled by the apex court, proposed mandating front-of-pack for packaged food and beverages with red-coloured hexagonal shape for food products that are high in any two or more nutrients—saturated fat, sugar or salt.

India has been facing a sharp rise in consumption of ultra-processed foods. The Economic Survey for FY26 said the domestic ultra-processed food market grew over 150% between 2009 and 2023.

Petitioner 3S and Our Health Society also urged FSSAI to base labels on total sugar, salt and fat, rather

than only added nutrients as proposed in its August 28 affidavit.

“...the negative impact of a food product is not only because of the added sugar but due to the total sugar content,” the filing said, citing fruit concentrates and products containing jaggery as examples where a product could have high overall sugar content despite little or no added sugar.

The rejoinder also called for larger warnings, covering 15-20% of the front display besides being prominent and visible from a distance, suggesting that the size of the warning hexagon bespecified in relation to the overall size of the package. The warning text must be one point larger than the font used in the back-of-pack nutrition table, FSSAI has proposed.

The petitioner further urged the regulator to build on its 2022 draft front-of-pack regulations instead of initiating a fresh consultation process, arguing that doing so would cause avoidable delay.

The 2022 Draft Food Safety and Standards (Labelling & Display) Amendment Regu-

lations had already undergone public consultation and contained a proposed definition of high fat, sugar and salt (HFSS) foods, according to material annexed to the rejoinder.

The petitioner sought treating the 2022 process as a continuing regulatory exercise and introducing the final warning-label framework expeditiously.

The rejoinder has also raised questions over how FSSAI arrived at its latest proposal. It said the regulator's compliance affidavit didn't disclose the internal consultation, food authority resolution or agenda item through which the proposed red-hexagon warning design and thresholds based on “added sugar” and “added saturated fat” were considered or approved.

The petitioner has separately sought mandatory bilingual warnings in English and Hindi, saying front-of-pack labels must be immediately understandable to a wider section of Indian consumers.

It argued that using both languages would reduce linguistic barriers and make the proposed warnings more accessible.

The filing cited bilingual food labelling in other jurisdictions and existing Indian rules needing critical information in English and Hindi in some food categories.

Moving Further Upmarket

►► From Page 1

While Swiss makers have sought to cushion the blow by moving further upmarket—lifting prices as volumes fell—that's only protecting the largest brands like Rolex, Patek Philippe and Cartier, which have a cult-like following. Mid-market players and suppliers are being hit hard.

The ultra-high segment continues to command “collector interest, but it's a tougher market for those in the middle,” said Rodolfo Festa-Bianchet, CEO and co-founder of Bianchet, whose watches fall in the higher end of the range. Gen Z and young millennials are less driven by status and brand loyalty, and are “more about excitement, emotion, discovery,” said Babin.

Younger buyers are helping fuel the secondary market too. They are comfortable buying secondhand and vintage watches online, where they can avoid waiting lists, access discontinued models and get immediate gratification rather than waiting months or years for a new piece.

Babin added that the industry has been too cautious and conservative in responding to changing tastes, focusing on technical improvements while failing to deliver bold new ideas. He pointed to the Royal Poin collaboration between Audemars Piguet and Swatch as an example of the kind of

disruption that he said can attract new buyers without alienating existing ones. The collection, unveiled this year, recast Royal Oak design codes in an accessible, colorful pocket-watch format aimed in part at younger consumers.

Such radical departures have been few and far between, Babin bemoaned. “This is really what we are missing, this type of innovation more often and for more brands. If we don't do that, it will be very difficult to recover volumes.”

To make matters worse, competition is intensifying. Chinese-made movement quality is now comparable to ETA SA or Sellita for standard complications, said Babin. Chinese luxury jeweler Laoou, which became one of the country's most viral consumer brands, is cited as evidence that Western incumbents risk getting rapidly displaced.

Chinese watchmakers are also increasingly selling mechanical watches globally through online channels, bypassing traditional retail networks and adding more pressure on Swiss products, particularly mid-priced ones.

That section of the market is also having to take on Japanese brands—Seiko, Citizen, Casio—that do well because they don't really try to trade up the way the Swiss manufacturers do, said Oliver Müller, founder of LuxeConsult, an industry advisory firm.

Analytics Department, 8th Floor,
NEWA Bhakti Knowledge Park, Airoli, Navi Mumbai - 400708

CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

RefNo: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 Dated: 05.09.2026

Corrigendum with reference to RFP No: SBI/GITC/Analytics/2026/2027/1477 dated 25.07.2026 has been published on Bank's website. For details, please visit 'Procurement News' at <https://www.sbi.bank.in>

Place: Mumbai Deputy General Manager

Date: 06.09.2026 Analytics Department (DB - Business)

GOVERNMENT OF HIMACHAL PRADESH
DEPARTMENT OF MPP & POWER
GLOBAL INVITATION OF BIDS FOR IMPLEMENTATION OF HYDRO ELECTRIC PROJECTS IN HIMACHAL PRADESH
CORRIGENDUM OF NOTICE INVITING PROPOSALS

In partial modification of Notice Inviting Proposals (NIP) for implementation of 27 Hydro Electric Projects (HEPs) upto 25 MW having total capacity 300.9 MW with free power royalty rate uniformly @12% + 1% for entire period i.e. 40 years published on 11.07.2026, which is also uploaded in the Directorate of Energy website i.e. <https://doehimachal.nic.in>, it is to inform that the last date of sale of Bid Documents, last date of submission of Bids and the date of opening of Bids are hereby extended as under :-

Last date for sale of Bid Documents : 07.10.2026 upto 1700 Hours
Tentative date of Pre-Bid Conference : 15.10.2026
Last date of submission of Bids : 30.10.2026 upto 1300 Hours (IST)
Date of opening of Bids : 30.10.2026 at 1500 Hours (IST) onwards

Note : If the Last date for submission of Bids or the date of opening of bids happens to be a holiday declared by the Government of Himachal Pradesh in Shimla, the Bids will be submitted and opened on the next working day in the same order and at the same time.

The other terms & conditions of earlier published Notice Inviting Proposals on 11.07.2026 shall remain the same.

For & on behalf of the Governor of HP
Sd/-
Director (Energy)
Directorate of Energy, Govt. of HP
Tel. +91-177-2673552, Fax +91-177-2673553
e-mail : ceenergy09@gmail.com

Advt.No.:0869/05/09/2026

Invitation to Transaction Advisors

Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited (GIFTCL) has floated an Invitation Notice inviting a Transaction Advisor for advisory services of an International School with International Baccalaureate (IB) and/or Cambridge Assessment International Education (CAIE) in GIFT City.

For enquiries: bo.query@giftgujarat.in - +91 79 6170 8300

GUJARAT INTERNATIONAL FINANCE TEC-CITY COMPANY LIMITED (GIFTCL)
EPS Building No.49A, Block No. 49, Zone IV, Gyan Marg, GIFT City, Gujarat, India – 382050.
Tel.: +91 79 6170 8300 | CIN: U75100GJ2007SGC051160



From ‘I have nothing to wear’ to ‘I have nothing to wear in my colour’— colour analysis is having a moment. Think ‘*mera wala blue*’, but for your wardrobe. **Khushi Vora** and **Shannika Ramos** help you find your true colours

khushi.vora@timesofindia.com & shannika.ramos@timesofindia.com

PALETTE CLEANSE

Ever seen those viral influencer reels where someone sits, head covered and makeup-free, while an ‘expert’ drapes fabric swatches around their neck, flipping through colours like a live Pantone deck until one shade makes everything click? The format has spawned countless reels, including the latest by RichTok queen Becca Bloom, who did it for her cat to find the right wallpaper for his room. Before you roll your eyes and dismiss it as rich people pish-tosh, know that colour analysis is currently a popular styling method that helps people find the colours most flattering to

them based on many factors such as skin undertone, hair and eye colour, etc. Its roots lie in early 20th-century colour theory, particularly artist Johannes Itten’s work linking colouring to harmonious palettes. It entered mainstream fashion in the 1970s and ‘80s through image consultants such as Carole Jackson, whose 1981 bestseller *Color Me Beautiful* popularised the four-season system—Spring, Summer, Autumn and Winter. Today, consultants use expanded systems, sometimes with 12 or 16 seasons, to guide choices in clothing, makeup, hair colour and accessories.

Huedunnit

The process starts with assessing the ‘SHE’ factor — skin, hair and eye pigment — to determine which tones complement you best. Modern systems use drapes, flags and fabric swatches to identify flattering palettes. Sessions typically last one to three hours in natural light, with clients bare-skinned and dressed in neutral tones. The effects can be dramatic, says Sonia Dubey Dewan, founder of the Indian School of Image Management. “In some colours,

[the client’s] face will light up and pigmentation, scars and dark circles will literally vanish.” Wrong colours can have the opposite effect, says Ritika Rele, founder of Rele Colour. “It ages one in an instant. It deepens under-eye shadows, draws out redness and uneven pigmentation, exaggerates skin texture and flattens facial definition,” she explains. But finding your colour is more nuanced, moving through three key steps.

SHADE MATCH

- Step 1: Undertones**
Understand your skin’s undertone — warm, cool or neutral.
- Step 2: Seasons**
Colours are narrowed through the four-season system — spring, summer, autumn, winter — where shades are differentiated by value and intensity. Value is how light or dark a colour is from white to black. Intensity refers to how vivid or muted a colour appears.
- Step 3: Flows**
Flows identify which trait — hue, value or intensity — is most dominant in your colouring.

In the 16-colour system, these flows are:
Warm vs. cool: Undertone-dominant
Light vs deep/dark: Value-dominant
Bright/clear vs muted/soft: Intensity-trait



Shady business

Most colour analysts say Jackson’s book is the Holy Grail of the business. Dewan says, “It was the first time she had introduced the concept of seasons and made it accessible to the general public.” However, for decades, these frameworks were exclusively for Western skin tones. “Historically, colour analysis was built around lighter skin, hair and eye combinations,” says Rele. “But now the industry is recognising that the same assumptions cannot be applied to everyone.” Over the past 15 years, the

world has shifted to the 16-colour system, which is more universal in nature. Social media has also connected users with experts and communities worldwide. Gwen Janelle Tan, founder of Singapore-based colour

consultancy StyleForth, says an Instagram collaboration with an Indian influencer reached about four million views and resulted in an influx of Indian clients.

“We have trained over 400 people. People say that it’s such a new thing. Frankly, it has been around for more than 40 years.”
— Sonia Dubey Dewan, founder, Indian School of Image Management

Colour coded

In a world where AI has an opinion on everything, can it also tell us which colours look good on us? It has a good shot. Upload a natural, well-lit selfie, feed AI a detailed prompt and voilà, it can analyse your undertone, contrast and best shades in under a minute.
Try: “Act as my colour consultant and analyse my skin undertone, hair and eye colour, and place me in the 16-season colour category.”
If a selfie feels like oversharing, there’s a workaround. Use a photo-editing app’s colour picker to sample your skin, hair and eyes, then copy the six-digit hex codes.
Try: “Act as a professional colour consultant and analyse my seasonal palette using these exact hex codes. Cover my undertone and contrast, seasonal typology, best and worst colours, and jewellery metals.”

Match point

The clientele is not limited to fashion enthusiasts. Tan caters to C-suite executives, directors, business owners and politicians. Despite misconceptions that the clientele is only women, Tan says, men make up about 20% of her clients. Dewan spotted the demand early on. During her corporate workshops in 2011, around 85-90% of participants who showed interest were men. Both conduct workshops and seminars for corporate clients. “When we brief them, we talk about their lifestyles, work environments and colour psychology,” says Tan, who has worked with Porsche, Chanel, Uniqlo and LinkedIn.



Cost of colours
Individual consultations
- StyleForth: **SG\$180-999** (approx. ₹13,000-74,000)
- Indian School of Image Management (ISIM): ₹2,000-10,000
Group Sessions
- StyleForth: **SG\$2,000-5,000** (approx. ₹1.48-3.71 lakh)
- ISIM: ₹1,500-₹3,000 per person, ₹15,000-30,000 for a group of 10

Pigment of imagination



Experts agree: There are no bad colours. If a consultant tells you to avoid a colour, stay away. “There can be a

version of that colour that suits you,” says Dewan. Rele says, “Understanding your colours lets you use them to change how people perceive you.” And the idea extends beyond the wardrobe. “In media training, when we are getting people camera-ready, we use colour analysis,” explains Dewan. “We use the colours on the basis of the [mood of]

news to tweak perception.” Colour psychology can come into play in everyday situations as well. For an important meeting, Tan suggests wearing green, which is associated with growth, both in nature and the stock market. Rele says it does help in choosing the right outfit. Once you’ve nailed your season, shopping becomes a whole lot easier.

“For men, once you know eight or 10 core colours, getting dressed almost solves itself.”
— Ritika Rele, founder, Rele Colour

WEEKEND POSER

Do Flip-Flops Impact Our Feet Health?



Jennifer Lawrence wore flip-flops to the 2023 Cannes Film Festival

Dr Paul Langer

How bad are flip-flops, really? Are you inflicting lasting damage on your feet every time you wear them?

According to some experts, wearing flip-flops will cause acute injuries, such as sprains, or contribute to more insidious injuries, such as plantar fasciitis. Some even claim they can contribute to hammertoes and bunions.

While it is reasonable to be cautious about flip-flop use for those who may be vulnerable to lower-extremity conditions, are they really that bad for everyone? The answer might surprise you.

SOLE, MATE

It is true that the risk of falling is higher in flip-flops, but this risk applies to all shoes that do not secure well to the foot such as high heels, mules, clogs or any poorly fitting shoes.

Additionally, there is no evidence in the research that flip-flops increase the risk of heel pain or toe alignment changes in people with healthy feet any more than other types of footwear. Heel pain, hammertoes and bunions are very common in the general population, even those who have never worn flip-flops. Many factors contribute to these foot concerns including genetics, lifestyle and biomechanical imbalances.

As a general rule of thumb, anyone with poor balance, osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, a history of lower-extremity surgery, diabetes, lower-extremity swelling, peripheral neuropathy, peripheral vascular disease, neurodegenerative conditions or gait abnormalities should avoid not just flip-flops, but any footwear that does not strap securely to the foot including at the heel. People with these conditions are more likely to fall or worsen existing issues when wearing unsupportive footwear.

Even if you don't have any of the health concerns listed above, remember that flip-flops are really made for walking on flat, dry surfaces only.

SHOE VALUE

Flip-flops place greater demand on the muscles and joints of the feet than conventional shoes, which can help build strength in healthy feet. Wearing them for short periods initially, alongside foot-strengthening exercises, can help the feet adjust.

They also allow the feet to spread more naturally than many shoes. This matters because poorly fitting footwear is a common cause of foot pain: A 2018 study found that up to 72% of people wore incorrectly fitting shoes, with improper fit associated with foot pain.

Having a variety of comfortable footwear options is a good strategy to maintain foot health—and for many people, that strategy can include flip-flops.

—The Washington Post



How Nomads Influenced Indian Cooking



Prime Minister Narendra Modi recently attended the opening of the sixth World Nomad Games in Kyrgyzstan. Kyrgyzstan held the first in 2014 and has used this Central Asia version of the Olympics to raise its national profile. The Games have drawn attention for eye-catching sports like wrestling and horseback (and wrestling on horseback!), but also

for focusing on the often-marginalised world of nomads.

In *Nomads: The Wanderers Who Shaped our World*, Anthony Sattin explains why communities in constant motion preferred orally transmitted tales to written histories: "Texts needed to be transported, libraries were vulnerable, and words themselves risked being misunderstood or reinterpreted." But this meant that history was set by people in settled cities who were often hostile to rootless travellers. Nomads were blamed for bringing disease and destruction — as well as some dubious eating habits.

One example is the myth of the raw meat eating Mongols or Tartars. They were said to slaughter cattle and put slices of meat beneath their saddles before starting the day's ride. By night, the meat would be tenderised and easy



to eat. There's little evidence of this happening, but it led to a dish of raw meat chopped with herbs and mixed with raw egg being called steak tartare. In reality, nomads were more likely to grill or boil meats — kebabs and the boiled dumplings called *manti* (like *momos*) are the real nomadic food



heritage across Asia.

Sattin notes that the word 'nomad' itself derives from the ancient Indo-European term *nomos*, meaning a field or pasture: "Out of this root word grows *nomas*, meaning 'a member of a wandering pastoral tribe' and implying 'someone looking for pasture...'"

Bound documents the life of the Van Gujjars, a Muslim community who herd buffaloes from the Shivalik hills in winter to the Himalayas in the summer, making a living by selling their milk. It is a hard life, not least from the constant harassment from officials, who want to end their age-old practices of foraging fodder in the forest tracts. Benanav did one migration with them and noted how hunger was a constant, yet the community never killed their animals, even burying them when they died. Their diet was vegetarian, based on milk, flour and what vegetables they could buy or forage on the way.

Sattin describes how nomads are acutely tuned to the lands they travel through: "They knew their environment in a way that can only be acquired through living on an equal footing with everything in that world... through a recognition that we humans are dependent on our surroundings, something those of us who live in towns and cities too easily forget." Nomads must learn

to read the weather, the patterns of animal lives and the value of plants, since this knowledge could mean the difference between life and death during a journey.

Nomads were also always looking for products that could be taken to cities to sell. Tea and dried fruits were an example, light to carry, high-value to trade and energy-giving for nomads to consume themselves. Another was *asafoetida*, a strong-smelling gum produced by a herb that grew naturally in Central Asia. This was used as a medicine, before finding real value in Indian cooking.

Nomadic traders, like the *kabuliwalla* of Tagore's famous story, brought hing to India, though it was more romantic to write of him selling dried fruits!

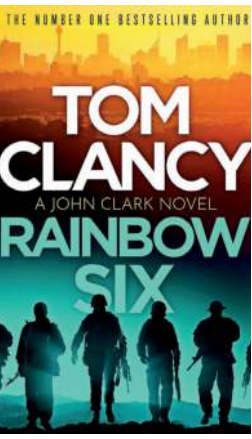
India still gets most of its *hing* from Central Asia, and Kyrgyzstan has been growing in importance as a supplier. Perhaps PM Modi found time to enquire after this trade that originated in the world of the nomads that was celebrated at the Games he watched.



The OPEC directors at a meeting. The heist was a result of a disagreement within OPEC



(From left) *The Bourne Identity* (1988), *Carlos* (2010) and *Rainbow Six* (1998) all depicted Carlos



Joby Warrick

December 21, 1975. A group of six heavily armed terrorists arrived at the world headquarters of OPEC, the international oil cartel, in Vienna, Austria. Inside the building, dozens of officials and dignitaries had gathered for the cartel's annual conference.

As the terrorists entered the building, the group greeted the lone policeman at the entrance in German. The officer nodded and let them pass.

Once inside, they covered their faces, stuffed grenades into their pockets and loaded their submachine guns. They then burst into the conference centre. The officials, 62 in all, including some of the world's wealthiest oil magnates, were declared hostages — prisoners of an unknown gang that had just pulled off an audacious attack in broad daylight in the heart of Europe.

MEET CARLOS

Who were the terrorists? What did they want? Even decades later, their true motives remain murky. Among the six, only one had a criminal record. Though only 26, he was the gang's leader. Watching his mates from beneath a stylish black beret, he turned out to be only too eager to talk. "I am the famous Carlos," he revealed openly. "You know who I am."

But who was Carlos, really? Fifty years since his most shocking act, and 30 since he was arrested in Sudan in 1994, he still remains a mythical figure in popular imagination.

People know him as an enigmatic outlaw whose pursuit of luxury and beautiful women made him a tabloid star. He was the inspiration for several novels and films. With a reputation that mingled fact and fiction in equal parts, he was the first celebrity terrorist.

LIFE IN PRISON

Today, Carlos is 76 and is serving life imprisonment in a prison outside Paris. Even here, guards use Carlos, his chosen *nom de guerre*, instead of Ilich Ramírez Sánchez, the name given to him by his Venezuelan parents. He dresses smartly — khaki jeans, a sweater and a leather bomber — walks slowly but without a stoop and greets the guards with a smile. He even flirts with

prison officials. "Are you a real blonde?" he asks the only woman in the room.

When finally persuaded to talk, the toll from age and his many years in relative isolation becomes clearer. Carlos repeats himself and sometimes loses the thread of what he was saying. One statistic from his past, however, remains unquestionable. "I killed 83 people by my own hand," he says.

The gang held 62 people hostage. Young Carlos — with his leather coat, light beard and a rakish beret — held more than a passing resemblance to Che Guevara. With his outsized ego and flair for showmanship, he took centre stage. By the end of the ordeal, which lasted three days, some of the captives would even ask for his autograph.

Carlos threatened to execute hostages at 15-minute intervals if their demands weren't met. These included broadcasting their pro-Palestinian statements on TV and radio every two

hours and arranging for a long-haul aircraft with crew to fly them wherever they wanted to go.

MEMORY GAMES

Carlos has always been forgetting uncomfortable facts. During his trial, he could remember nothing about the killings of two police officers and an informant in Paris.

Then, in subsequent trials, he claimed to know nothing about tossing a grenade

into a crowded shopping centre in Paris in 1974, or about the bombings and shootings in Europe and Lebanon after the arrest of two gang members in 1982.

But most importantly, what can he remember about the OPEC crisis? Who put the gang up to the job? The attack's main sponsor never identified themselves, though speculation was rampant that it was Iraq's Saddam Hussein.

Recent evidence, however, has pointed to a different theory: The attack was ordered by one of the oil cartel's own members, the Libyan leader Muammar Gaddafi. Thanks to secretly recorded conversations facilitated by Carlos's lawyer, details gradually emerged.

MILLIONS IN RANSOM

Carlos would ultimately spend most of his career in a similar fashion: A terrorist for hire, carrying out bombings and shootings on behalf of powerful clients who kept their sponsorship hidden.

But things didn't end well for him. Gaddafi soon changed his mind and abandoned the gang even as the hostage crisis was still underway.

Carlos eventually fled, making off with millions of dollars in ransom payments, but he was rejected by Gaddafi and allies. For the rest of his criminal career, Carlos would be mostly on his own. An intense, deep-seated grudge still endures. "A crazy guy," Carlos said of the dictator. "Because of Gaddafi, we almost all died."

'NOT THE FIRST PLANE I'VE HIJACKED'

But on that wintry day in late 1975, it was all still ahead of him. Carlos had his 62 hostages, many of them VIPs he could later swap for money. Twelve hours into the kidnapping, he also had command of a chartered DC-9 passenger jet, which was soon crowded with OPEC ministers and their aides.

Manfred Pollak, an Austrian pilot who volunteered to fly the aircraft, became alarmed at the sight of oxygen tanks that had been brought aboard to aid a wounded terrorist. Pollak worried about the risk of an explosion and summoned Carlos to the cockpit to issue a stern warning. Even a tiny spark could lead to disaster for passengers and terrorists alike, the pilot said. "I know, I know!" Carlos replied, visibly annoyed. "This is not the first airplane I've hijacked!"

"But for me, it's the first time!" Pollak shot back.

Carlos had lied. In his brief terrorist career, he'd done many things, but commandeering a plane wasn't on the list. His first attempt would be anything but smooth. He'd initially intended to fly to Tripoli, the Libyan capital, but the plane lacked sufficient fuel. So he set his sights on Algiers. Later, he decided it should be Tunis. Or maybe Baghdad.

The outside world was watching, mesmerised, to learn the fate of the hostages and their colourful captor: Carlos, the narcissistic young killer who had dreamed of gaining international renown as a revolutionary, had at last secured his moment in the spotlight. The other details he would make up as he went along.

— The Washington Post

In a prison near Paris, 50 years since he terrorised the world, Ilich Ramírez 'Carlos' Sánchez retains his bluster, but he's forgetting the details

A DAY WITH THE JACKAL

Why We're Still Nuts for This Metal Toy, 125 Years Later

Meccano has fired children's imagination for decades, with a Nobel Prize winner and a prime minister among its fans

More than a billion sets have been sold of the metal construction toy Meccano — which can be used to build everything from Ferris wheels to fighter jets — since its creation by British toymaker Frank Hornby in 1901.

Devised for his children at his kitchen table, its reusable metal parts, fastened with nuts and bolts, revolutionised educational play. Originally launched as *Mechanics Made Easy*, 'Meccano' — adopted in

1907 — is believed to derive from the phrase 'make and know'.

BUILDING A COMMUNITY

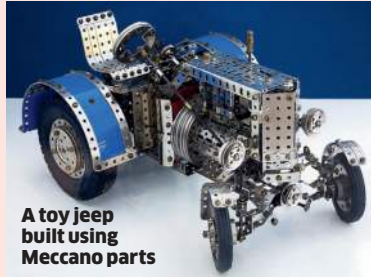
The world's first construction toy — it predates Lego, which was created by Danish carpenter Ole Kirk Christiansen in 1932 — even helped the World War II effort.

In 1914, Hornby opened Meccano's Binns Road factory in Liverpool, UK. The launch of *Meccano Magazine* in 1916 and the Meccano Guild in 1919 built



a global community, while the 1920s saw Hornby expand into model railways, Dinky miniatures, Kemex chemistry sets and Elektron electric kits.

Sharon Brown, curator of land transport, work and industry at the Museum of Liverpool, says: "Facing early marketing struggles with Meccano, Hornby got a vital break when Professor [Henry] Hele-Shaw of Liverpool University certified it as



'based on sound engineering principles.' The endorsement skyrocketed sales."

Before World War II, mathematicians at Manchester University built early analogue computers from Meccano to solve complex equations. When metal toy production was banned in 1942, Meccano turned to wartime manufacturing, though the details remain undisclosed.

FINDING ITS PLACE

Brown says: "Nobel winner Harry Krotto linked his 1996 chemistry prize directly to playing with Meccano as a child."

Meccano collector Richard Payn knows a few more famous fans: "Harold Wilson, the British prime minister from the '70s, had a Meccano set. Denys Fisher, the engineer who created the Spirograph, was also inspired by it."

Trevor Baylis, inventor of the Freeplay radio, also took inspiration from his childhood Meccano sets.

And Roland Moreno used Meccano to build and test the original card-handling mechanism origin that helped him to secure his patent that for the smart card, or memory chip, in 1974.

Meccano's UK production ended in 1981; today, the brand is owned by Canadian toy company Spin Master and manufactured through partners across Europe, Asia and Latin America

— Daily Mirror

VITALS

Valverde Named in Uruguay Squad for India Friendly

Kolkata: Real Madrid star Federico Valverde will headline a star-studded Uruguay squad named for next month's international friendly against India, with the two-time world champions, led by head coach Diego Forlan, bringing a formidable mix of established internationals and emerging talents. India will take on Uruguay at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan on October 6, as part of a high-profile series of international friendlies. **PTI SQUAD** Goalkeepers: Santiago Mele, Christopher Fiermarin, Ignacio de Arruabarrena, Sebastian Jaume, Thiago Cardozo. Defenders: Kevin Amaro, Jose Luis Rodriguez, Guillermo Varela, Nahitan Nandez, Santiago Mourino, Nicolas Marichal, Ronald Araujo, Alexander Barboza, Jose Maria Gimenez, Juan Rodriguez, Sebastian Boselli, Santiago Bueno, Sebastian Caceres, Mathias Olivera, Joaquin Piquerez, Lucas Olaza, Marcelo Saracchi, Juan Manuel Sanabria. **Midfielders:** Emiliano Martinez, Lucas Torreira, Rodrigo Bentancur, Facundo Bernal, Santiago Homenchenko, Federico Valverde, Agustin Canobbio, Matias Abaldo, Facundo Pellistri, Luciano Rodriguez, Maximiliano Araujo, Lucas Villalba, Brian Rodriguez, Rodrigo Zalazar, Diego Rossi, Giorgian de Arrascaeta. **Forwards:** Martin Satriano, Agustin A. Martinez, Rodrigo Aguirre, Federico Vinas, Miguel Merentiel, Darwin Nunez, Alvaro Rodriguez

LONDON SQUASH CLASSIC

Anaha's Impressive Run Ends in Quarters

London: India's Anahat Singh bowed out of the London Squash Classic after going down to Malaysian world No. 5 Sivasangari Subramaniam 4-11, 4-11 in the women's quarterfinals of the PSA Gold event. The reigning world junior champion Anahat suffered a 4-11, 4-11 defeat on Friday. Anahat had beaten world No. 11 Neli Gillis to make the quarterfinals. The world No. 20 will next compete in the Qatar Classic from September 12 in the build up to the Asian Games in Japan, which starts on September 19. **PTI**

Mbappe Misses Penalty as Betis Beat Real Madrid



Kylian Mbappe missed a late penalty as Troy Parrott scored his first goal for Real Betis in a 1-0 win over Real Madrid on Friday, ending Jose Mourinho's side's perfect start to the La Liga season. Madrid had won each of their first three matches under Mourinho in his second spell in charge, but Betis goalkeeper Alvaro Valls denied Mbappe from the spot deep into stoppage time to seal a memorable victory at La Cartuja. **AFP**

F1: MONZA GRAND PRIX

Alpine's Gasly Seizes First Career Pole Ahead of Russell

Monza: French Formula One driver Pierre Gasly upset the favourites to grab a stunning career-first pole position with Renault-owned Alpine at the Italian Grand Prix on Saturday. Gasly, who won at Monza with Red Bull-owned AlphaTauri (now Racing Bulls) in 2020 and lives in nearby Milan, seized pole from Mercedes's George Russell with his final effort and a lap of one minute 21.786 seconds - 0.060 quicker than the Briton. The pole was also the first for Renault's team since they became Alpine in 2021. McLaren's Oscar Piastri qualified third at the 'Temple of Speed' but was then handed a three-place drop for impeding Red Bull's Liam Lawson. **Reuters**

India Spin Pakistan into Submission

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP Bowlers dismiss Pakistan for 55 before batters chase down target in just 8.4 overs to win by 7 wickets

Young spinners Shree Charani and Prema Rawat strangled Pakistan with incisive spells as India crushed their arch-rivals by seven wickets in a one-sided Women's Asia Cup T20 contest on Saturday.

Harmanpreet Kaur, who became the first international captain, male or female, to lead India in 150 T20Is, had plenty to celebrate as her spinners bowled Pakistan out for 55 in 18.1 overs, their lowest total in the format.

Fittingly, Harmanpreet finished the game with a six down the ground.

India's spinners - 22-year-old left-arm orthodox bowler Charani (3-7 in four overs), 24-year-old leg-spinner Rawat (3-9 in four overs) and part-time wrist-spinner Shafali Verma (1-10 in three overs) - dismantled the Pakistan batting lineup. Deepti Sharma (2-5 in 3.1 overs) completed the rout.

EUROPEAN DREAM ETPL Looks to Redraw Cricket's Map

With cricket's wealth concentrated in a handful of markets, a new T20 league is betting on Europe becoming the game's next growth story



Anand Vasu REGARDLESS

There's more money in cricket than ever before, but there are fewer opportunities and pathways where they are needed most. It sounds absurd, but the reality is that cricket's franchise dollars are concentrated in the Indian Premier League (IPL); its rupees lie with the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), thanks to the Indian team's enormous following; and its commercial alliances are limited to England and Australia.

While those who have cricketing currency are rapidly multiplying their piles with little innovation or effort, the geographies and stakeholders that need it most are scrambling to survive. The West Indies can barely organise domestic fixtures; Sri Lanka's gorgeous Test grounds lie vacant for much of the year because playing the longest format costs money they don't have. New Zealand's players have to check with their franchise before committing to a series for their country.

Cricket has been loath to admit that it is a colonial sport. Its international footprint is a subset of the Commonwealth, and attempts to reach expatriates in North America or the population of China have proven futile. A glaring opportunity has existed in continental Europe, but it has been unattractive to the powers that be because they have never needed the votes of the Irish, the Scottish or the Dutch at the global boardroom table.

In 2019, the first private foray to fill this gap emerged with the Euro Slam T20, but the Covid-19 pandemic ensured the event was a non-starter. In 2025, when the European T20 Premier League stepped in, they realised that much more work was needed before they could put boots on the ground.

"We knew you're not going to get very many chances at doing this for the first time. And we wanted to do it right," Abhishek Bachchan, co-founder of ETPL, told ET Sport. "Initially, we felt we weren't entirely ready. I'm very happy that I have like-minded co-founders who believe that the planning and preparation is the majority of a start."

The cricket boards of Ireland, Scotland and the Netherlands were among those understanding partners, and it's a huge credit to them that they took this leap of faith, given how often the promise of Indian money has ended up being empty. When the six franchises sold, and teams were fronted by the likes of Rahul Dravid and Steve Waugh, credibility stopped being an issue.

Ultimately, though, the ETPL will live or die by the quality of cricket it



Former India captain Rahul Dravid, who co-owns Dublin Guardians, interacts with the fans during a match ETPL

produces. To test the depth of those waters, listen to George Dockrell of the Dublin Guardians. Dockrell has won games for Ireland with ball and bat, has played 134 ODIs and 159 T20Is on top of two Tests.

"The challenge of growing cricket in places such as Ireland, Scotland and the Netherlands - the heart of cricket in Europe - is that while you get opportunities in the World Cup, there's a long time between opportunities," he says.

"The only real demand from players in these countries has been for more fixtures against better opposition." Dockrell is 34 now, but when he was 17, he had to miss an ODI against Australia to sit a school exam. A year later, he trapped Sachin Tendulkar lbw in a World Cup game. Ireland beat better teams, including the old freemans England, but they were still left waiting for scraps in terms of fixtures.

Explaining why the ETPL could be a game-changer for the region, Dockrell says, "For all those Irish kids who are watching, just seeing that this is some-

thing that they can do in the future gives them something that they can work towards."

Scott Edwards of Amsterdam Flames understands multi-country co-operation, the basis of the ETPL, better than most. He was born in Tonga, raised in Australia and went on to captain the Netherlands.

"At the ETPL you play with and against the best in the world for a set period. In a World Cup, you get maybe four games, and if you don't make it to the next round, that's it," he says. "The security element of knowing the ETPL is there makes cricket a viable thing to pursue for youngsters."

The Netherlands can offer full-time contracts to only eight players, not even enough to field one team. But ETPL contracts can allow future players space to pursue a pathway rather than merely dream. "I've loved playing for the Netherlands. Every game you play is highly consequential because there's so much riding on it," says Edwards.

When the Indian cricket team loses, it shrugs and moves on; every loss by the Netherlands sets cricket in the country back.

The ETPL can ease some of this pressure. But as a project, it can be neither vanity nor charity, and it appears that the league owners recognise this. Ask Bachchan what success looks like to him, and he takes a pause. "This is a tough question with no simple answer. Being in the business of sport, you have to be honest, true and faithful to both those words, business and sport. Neither can do without the other," he says.

"At the heart of it has to be passion, and the sport. Without that as your foundation, the business won't matter. The business has to come next, not second, but next. When you cannot infuse enough funds into a quality competitive product, you're fighting a losing battle. The important thing is that you get the sport right. Make sure it's competitive, world-class and aspirational. And the business has to make sense: nobody's here to burn very large holes in their pocket. Success is measured in terms of viewership because, without fans and viewership, your sport is nothing. Financial performance is important."

From being utterly impoverished, cricket has grown into a mega-business. It learnt that financial performance is important, but somewhere along the way it became the only important thing. The golden goose is prolific, but if the game does not want to put all its eggs in one basket, it's vital that leagues such as the ETPL thrive.

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The Williams Show Goes On

Serena and Venus reunite their iconic doubles team, losing narrowly but thrilling the New York crowd

Jocelyn Noveck

New York: "Welcome to the Williams Show," read one fan's sign in Arthur Ashe Stadium on Friday night, as Venus and Serena Williams took the court for their doubles match, a quarter-century after first facing each other in the 2001 US Open final.

A quarter-century of playing pro tennis at a top level - at any level - is not a very common thing. And even more incredibly, the Williams sisters, now ages 46 and 44, showed they can still come agonizingly close to beating a top team that is cumulatively around half their age. In a three-set thriller that delighted a packed and vocal evening crowd, the sisters fell short only at the end, blowing a 5-0 lead in the final 10-point tiebreak to lose to Hao-Ching Chan of Taiwan and Maya Joint of Australia, 6-3, 6-7(6), 7-6(10-7).

So it was indeed quite a thrilling show - even the sisters themselves, narrowly defeated, walked off with smiles on their faces, though they declined to speak to the media afterward.

"It was an amazing match," Joint said. "They played really well, and I think just the atmosphere on the court ... I don't think either of us has experienced quite like that before. And playing two legends of the game is just a super special moment that we might not get again."

The hugely entertaining evening came four years after the sisters last played doubles together at Flushing Meadows. That match came just a few weeks after Serena Williams announced, in a poignant Vogue essay, that she was "evolving away from tennis." The headline used the dramatic word "farewell," though Williams presciently noted she disliked the word "retirement."

Whatever the wording, though, the message was clear: Daughter Olympia really wanted to be a big sister. And Williams knew she couldn't accomplish that and still play tennis the way she wanted. She could not, in other words, have it all.

"Something's got to give," Williams wrote, in words that resonated with many women, in sports and beyond.

Well, Olympia got her little sister. And this year, her Mom was fulfilling another of Olympia's requests: that she play doubles again at the US Open with Aunt Venus.

"You need to play with Auntie VeVe," 9-year-old Olympia told her. Serena Williams said this week on ABC's "Good Morning America."

"She said it so clear and so calm,"

Williams said. "She's like my mom, she doesn't really talk a lot, but when she does, you listen. And I was like, 'OK.'"

And so the sisters returned as a team to the tournament where Serena won six singles titles, and Venus two - one of them against Serena, who returned the favour the following year. That 2001 victory for the elder sister came a full quarter-century ago - which was enough to give fans goose bumps that this partnership is alive.

"I'm happy for them," said longtime tennis fan Nonie Green, of Arlington, Virginia, as she waited out a rain shower between matches earlier this week. "Father Time is undefeated. But I'm happy for them, even if they don't win."

They indeed didn't win Friday's match, but they made it a close fight - thrilling the crowd with some vintage volleys as they took the second set tiebreak to force a decider, then came close to winning that set.

But victory or defeat does not seem, for many fans, the point. The point is that they're back in the spotlight. **AP**

Potapova Sends Home Hope Anisimova Packing in Third Round



New York: American 10th seed Amanda Anisimova went out of the U.S. Open in the third round on Saturday, losing 6-2, 7-5 to Austrian Anastasia Potapova as she failed to recapture the magic of her run to the final a year ago. Potapova defended 13 of the 16 break points she faced to reach the fourth round in New York for the first time, where she will play either Russian Mirra Andreeva or Czech Nikola Pietrangola. "I think I'm the happiest person out here - maybe my coach is a little bit happier," said Potapova. "To play here gives me so many goosebumps when I come out on this court in front of this crowd." Anisimova, a runner-up at Wimbledon last year as well, has been unable to reach a tournament final in 2026. **Reuters**

The Reinvention of Raphinha

Barca wanted Alvarez to lead their attack. Instead, the Brazilian has stepped up as an unlikely solution at No. 9

Barcelona spent the summer fruitlessly pursuing Atletico Madrid striker Julian Alvarez but Raphinha's blistering start to the La Liga season suggests they may already have the firepower they need.

The Brazilian winger has bagged five goals in three games playing out of position as Barca's number nine ahead of Sunday's visit to Valencia at Mestalla.

Barca boast a 100 per cent record and are level on nine points with Jose Mourinho's revamped Real Madrid, and Real Betis who beat Los Blancos 1-0 on Friday.

The Catalan giants failed to land the forward they craved to replace Robert Lewandowski and Ferran Torres, who left earlier in the summer, and instead settled for a deadline day deal with Arsenal for Gabriel Jesus.

However even former Manchester City striker Jesus admits it will be hard for

him to upgrade an attack already flourishing with his compatriot Raphinha leading the way.

"I don't think I'm coming to improve (the team) because it's already... great," admitted Jesus at his presentation on Tuesday. "I'm just coming to help."

Raphinha is expected to keep his role as the team's centre-forward in the weeks ahead, although the start of the Champions League will encourage coach Hansi Flick to rotate.

Last season Raphinha suffered several injury problems, so Jesus could lighten his burden.

German coach Flick's arrival at Barca signified a new era not just for the team but for Raphinha himself, who was becoming frustrated under Xavi Hernandez.

With Flick at the helm the former Leeds United winger developed into a vital part



Raphinha (centre) has bagged five goals in three games playing out of position as Barcelona's No. 9

of Barca's system, helping the team claim back-to-back league titles and gaining the admiration of his team-mates.

"In this moment (Raphinha) is doing really great," said Flick on Saturday. "He's the best option for us at the moment in this position."

Flick was upset when Raphinha

How 'Brave' Small-town Club Elversberg is Shaking up German Football

James Ellingworth

Duesseldorf: The smallest team in the Bundesliga may be the most exciting.

From a town of just 13,000 people and operating on a shoestring budget, Elversberg made a big statement in their first-ever top-division game last week, stunning former champion Bayer Leverkusen 3-2.

Texas-born winger Cole Campbell intercepted a pass to score after becoming Elversberg's record signing as the team raced into a 3-0 lead before holding off a Leverkusen comeback.

Next, they earned a late 4-3 win at Borussia Moenchengladbach despite playing half the match with 10 men as they made it two wins from two this season in a dream start to their maiden top-flight campaign.

Elversberg have shown they can keep up with the big teams on their day.

"It's not easy, without question, because today we had 10 guys on the field making their Bundesliga debuts,"

coach Vincent Wagner said after his team beat Leverkusen. "Even if we get beaten heavily a couple of times we just need to play brave football because that's the only way we have a chance in this league."

Bravery is a word that comes up a lot at Elversberg. It's a concept that shapes the tactics, all about intense defending and quick attacks, and the transfer strategy.

Ignoring proven Bundesliga players for financial reasons - "Maybe we can afford one or two, but then we would break our whole wage structure" - technical director Josef Welzmueller is betting on finding high-potential young players other clubs have overlooked or undervalued.

The reported fee for Campbell of €6 million (\$6.96 million) was a



Elversberg players celebrate a goal against Bayer Leverkusen

club record but very modest by league standards.

"It was our record signing, which probably shows how much we believe in Cole," Welzmueller said. "He's a fantastic player."

He's very fast. He's very strong with the ball, very strong in one-on-one situations.

"He's a very good kid, very good character. We just want him to go in one-on-one situations and solve spaces for us, and we are very sure that he will have a breakout season."

Campbell arrived from Borussia Dortmund after struggling for playing time there and on loan at Hoffenheim. Alongside him was Francis Onyeka, a Leverkusen player on loan facing his own club, one of three

youngsters on loan in the squad.

"It's always bringing in high potential players," Welzmueller added. "We trust them, we want to give them the minutes other clubs are still holding back and that's also very brave in this aspect."

Just 9,307 people were packed into Elversberg's stadium to see the team make history. That's because one side is a construction site.

An already small venue has been reduced in size even further as the club rushes through expansion to reach the league minimum of 15,000 capacity by the spring.

When that's done, the Ursapharm-Arena - named for the local pharmaceutical company whose sponsorship has funded Elversberg's rise -

will be able to fit everyone in the town of Spiesen-Elversberg and nearly 2,000 more people.

The club's recruitment operation is undersized, too, with two "hard-working" scouts on staff, Welzmueller said. There are "very, very few" executives, which he argued means the club can make decisions fast.

The sudden rise of a team which was playing fourth-tier football as recently as 2022 still manages to surprise its own staff.

Welzmueller grew up a Bayern Munich fan and says facing his boyhood team on Sept. 13 will be "insane."

But it'll be just another game for a team which refuses to back down. "We have very much respect for the Bundesliga," Welzmueller said. "We don't fear anybody" **AP**

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